



CITY: Pg 2

Noida Airport to begin commercial ops from Jun 15



NATION: Pg 5

Kerala CM race shifts to high command



FILM: Pg 14

Priyanka teams up with Orlando for 'Reset'

SLAMS CONG FOR BACKSTABBING, BETRAYING TAMIL NADU

DMK says INDIA bloc is gone...

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: Upset with the Congress which backed actor Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in its bid to form the government in Tamil Nadu, an irked DMK on Thursday declared that the "INDIA bloc is gone" after the Congress snapped ties with MK Stalin-led party.

The dramatic fallout came amid growing uncertainty in the state after the Assembly poll results that threw up a fractured verdict, with none of the parties crossing the majority mark. The TVK emerged as the single largest party with 108 of 234 seats and decided to ally with the Congress, which has five MLAs, significantly altering the state's post-poll equations.

"INDIA bloc is gone," senior DMK leader TKS Elangovan said, accusing the Congress of betraying a long-standing ally.

Asked if the Left parties and the Viduthalaï Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) would remain with the DMK-led alliance, the DMK leader said they were free to decide their own political course.

"The CPI, CPI (M) and



Rahul Gandhi with MK Stalin

FILE PHOTO

VCK said they will consider (their decisions) with their respective leaderships. Whatever decision they take, we will support them. We will not force them to do anything," he said.

The Congress-TVK alignment has cast serious doubts over the future of the opposition INDIA bloc at the national level.

The DMK slammed the Congress, accusing it of "backstabbing" the DMK and betraying Tamil Nadu, despite party chief M K Stalin displaying maturity and conduct in a responsible manner.

Condemning the Congress for severing ties with the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) and entering into

a post-poll pact with the fledgling TVK, the DMK said the grand old party's decision to walk out of the alliance was strongly condemnable.

"The Congress has done to us in Tamil Nadu what the BJP does in many states," a resolution passed at the DMK MLAs-designate meeting chaired by party president and outgoing Chief Minister Stalin, said flaying the Congress "opportunistic political tilt."

"This shows that the Congress party has not changed its old character. The Congress was allotted one Rajya Sabha seat and 28 assembly seats in our alliance. It shifted to an alternative party within three days,

Continued on P4

TVK shops for numbers

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: Superstar Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), which made a blockbuster entry in Tamil Nadu's Assembly polls, has reached out to one more MLA as growing uncertainty clouds the government formation.

The TVK is learnt to have sought the support of Kamaraj S, the lone winning candidate of the Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK), led by TTV Dhinakaran.

The TVK's move comes amid a stalemate with Governor RV Arlekar, who remains unconvinced that the party can run an administration despite falling short of the required majority of 118 MLAs.

The TVK has scripted history by ending the Dravidian giants DMK and AIADMK's six decades old stranglehold on the Tamil Nadu government, winning 108 out of 234 seats. The halfway mark being



FILE PHOTO

Party reaches out to Left and VCK

118, he needs 10 more MLAs in his support to form the government.

The Congress has already pledged support to the TVK, adding five more MLAs to Vijay's favour, while two-year-old party also reached out to DMK allies like the VCK and the Left outfits.

Governor Arlekar on Thursday conveyed to TVK chief Vijay that his party does not have the requisite support to form the government and the fledgling party simultaneously stepped up its efforts to convince the Left parties, VCK and the IUML to rope them in to shore up numbers.

They are expected to spell out their stand on the matter within two days. The parties in contention

Continued on P4

'NO TERROR SANCTUARY IS SAFE'

Op Sindoor just the beginning: Military



Former Director General of Military Operations (DGMO) Lt Gen Rajiv Ghai, second left, Deputy Chief of Integrated Defence Staff Lt Gen Zubin A Minwalla, left, Air Marshal Awadhesh Kumar Bharati, second right, and Vice Admiral AN Pramod during a joint commanders' conference commemorating the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor, in Jaipur, Rajasthan, Thursday

PIC/PTI

MPOST BUREAU

JAIPUR: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday released a nearly 30-minute-long documentary on the first anniversary of India's Operation Sindoor, which last year struck terror infrastructure and military targets deep inside Pakistan.

The documentary is concise, yet highly detailed with tactical information from the operation that became the Indian military's most expansive multi-domain combat mission in half-a-century to punish Pakistan for its relentless support to cross-border terrorism.

The documentary highlights several interesting aspects of Operation Sindoor. One of them is the use of cyber assets to monitor Pakistan's critical systems. Another is the repositioning of space-based assets to make revisits of multiple areas of interest with the help of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). Simultaneously, India's intelligence agencies worked jointly and shared information seamlessly.

All this happened even before India started taking kinetic action on Pakistani targets, according to the documentary, suggesting the sheer scale and complexity involved

STARK WARNING TO PAKISTAN

» 'No sanctuary across the Line of Control is safe. We will hit everything. We will go after everything and that has been made clear in the new normal that the prime minister said last year'

» 'But the conditions, the timing and the method will be ours'

» In response to the Pahal-gam terror attack, India launched Operation Sindoor on May 7 last year carrying out airstrikes on nine terror infrastructures in Pakistan and Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir eliminating at least 100 terrorists

in the planning phase to make Operation Sindoor one of India's deadliest response to terror and its enablers.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is seen in the documentary talking about giving a free hand to the military to do whatever they do best in wiping out terror.

Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan said, "The operation demonstrated the ability of the Indian

Continued on P4

Guv dissolves Bengal Legislative Assembly

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Lok Bhavan on Thursday issued a Press release stating the formal dissolution of the Bengal Legislative Assembly in accordance with established norms.

"In exercise of the powers conferred upon the Governor under sub clause (b) of Clause (2) of Article 174 of the Constitution of India , Hon'ble Governor of West Bengal Shri R.N. Ravi has issued an order dissolving the West Bengal Legislative Assembly with effect from May 7, 2026 . The order has come into force in accordance with the constitutional provisions contained under Article 174 (2) (b) of the Constitution of India," the Press release stated.

A gazette notification in this regard was also issued by the state government.

Despite her electoral defeat—and while alleging vote rigging—Mamata Banerjee has declared that she will not resign from the post of Chief Minister. However, following the Governor's directive, even if she has not formally tendered her resignation, Banerjee effectively no longer holds the office of Chief Minister. For the time being, West Bengal has come under the ambit of President's Rule.

The tenure of the Mamata Banerjee government was valid until May 7, while the newly elected BJP government is scheduled to take its oath of office on May 9. Consequently, President's Rule has been imposed in the state for an interim period of two days.

NEW GOVT TO TAKE OATH ON MAY 9 IN PRESENCE OF PM MODI

Shah to chair meet today to decide BJP's first Bengal CM

PRADIP CHATTERJEE

KOLKATA: As Union Home minister Amit Shah arrives in Kolkata on Friday afternoon to chair a meeting with the BJP's 207 newly elected MLAs and finalise the name of the BJP chief minister of a BJP government in West Bengal, it marks the culmination of the party's long political journey from the fringes of the state's ideological landscape to the centre of power.

The BJP's rise in Bengal has been driven by years of organisational expansion, cultural repositioning, high-profile defections, polarising campaigns and hard-fought street battles in a region long considered resistant to its politics.

This is Shah's first trip to West Bengal since the BJP's landslide victory in the 2026 Assembly polls.

He will also oversee arrangements for the oath-taking ceremony of the chief minister and other Cabinet ministers,

Continued on P4

PM MODI AMONG KEY ATTENDEES

May 12 set for Assam BJP-led NDA oath sho

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI: The swearing-in ceremony of the newly elected BJP-led NDA government in Assam will be held on May 12, Chief Secretary Ravi Kota said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, several union ministers, chief ministers and deputy CMs of BJP-ruled states, and representatives from industries are expected to attend the function.

The oath-taking ceremony is scheduled to be held at the Veterinary Field, Khanapara, he said.

"Chaired a comprehensive review meeting with the DGP, Assam today to assess prepared-

GOVT FORMATION

» The oath-taking ceremony is scheduled to be held at the Veterinary Field, Khanapara

» Prime Minister Narendra Modi, several union ministers, chief ministers and deputy CMs of BJP-ruled states, and representatives from industries are expected to attend the function

» Union minister J P Nadda and Naib Singh Saini have been appointed as the observer and co-observer, respectively, for the election of the BJP Legislature party leader, which is likely to be held on May 10

ness for the forthcoming visit of the Hon'ble Prime Minister to attend the swearing-in ceremony of the newly elected Council of Ministers", Kota posted on X on

Wednesday night.

Arrangements related to security, traffic management, venue readiness, protocol, and inter-departmental coordination were

discussed in detail, he said.

"Emphasised the need for seamless execution, strict adherence to established protocols, and close coordination among all stakeholders," Kota said.

All departments concerned have been directed to maintain the highest level of preparedness to ensure the ceremony is conducted smoothly, securely, and in a manner befitting the significance of the occasion, he said.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma tendered his resignation to Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya, who asked him to continue as the head of the caretaker government.

Continued on P4

SUNSET FRAME



Bandra-Worli Sea Link silhouetted against the sunset sky, in Mumbai, on Wednesday

PTI

LAND 'FRAUD' CASE

ED raids aide of Pb CM's OSD

CHANDIGARH: The Enforcement Directorate on Thursday conducted searches at multiple locations in Punjab and Chandigarh, including the premises of an alleged close associate of an OSD in the CMO, as part of a money laundering probe into an alleged land fraud case, officials said.

They said about a dozen locations in Mohali and Chandigarh linked to Suntec City project, Ajay Sehgal, ABS Townships, Altus Builders, Dhir Constructions and associates are being searched under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Lau-



Bhagwant Mann

PIC/PTI

dering Act (PMLA).

A person named Nitin Gohal is also being searched by the agency and he is alleged to have "helped" builders who "defaulted" in payment of Greater Mohali Area Devel-

opment Authority (GMADA) fees and arranging "political protection" for them, ED officials said.

Officials claimed Gohal, an IT professional, was linked to Rajbir Ghuman, Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann.

The accused have been charged with fraud in obtaining CLU (change of land use) licences from GMADA and subsequently cheating public. They are alleged to have collected funds worth crores of rupees from the investors, the officials said.

See P6

INVESTIGATION HINTS AT PLANNED HIT

Police form SIT to probe Suvendu aide Rath's murder

GOURAB NETO

KOLKATA: Investigators probing the murder of Chandranath Rath, personal assistant to BJP leader and MLA Suvendu Adhikari, suspect the involvement of professional shooters. Police have formed multiple teams and an SIT to investigate the killing, while also recovering vehicles bearing fake number plates. Rath was shot dead in Madhyamgram on Wednesday night.

The murder has further escalated Bengal's volatile post-poll political tensions, triggering a fresh exchange of accusations between the BJP and the Trinamool Congress.



CID officials investigate the crime scene following the killing of BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari's close aide Chandranath Rath, on Thursday

PIC/PTI

While BJP leaders described the incident as a "politically motivated killing", the Trinamool demanded a court-monitored CBI probe into the case.

The SIT formed, which includes

Continued on P4

UP govt's veg-only cuisine map leaves kebabs behind

Lucknow's famed non-veg icons missing from ODOC list

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: It is difficult to imagine a conversation on Lucknow's culinary heritage without references to Tunday and Galouti kebabs or Awadhi biryani. Yet, these iconic dishes are missing from the Uttar Pradesh government's district-wise list of traditional food items notified under its 'One District One Cuisine' (ODOC) initiative, which features only vegetarian preparations.

The ODOC initiative, aimed at promoting regional delicacies through branding, packaging and market access, maps signature food items to each of the state's 75 districts. However, several celebrated



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

MISSING FROM THE MENU

» Among the notable omissions are Lucknow's famed Tunday and Galouti kebabs, Awadhi biryani and nihari, Rampur's mutton korma and seekh kebabs, and Bareilly's well-known mutton preparations

» The absence of these dishes has triggered debate among food historians and culinary experts

non-vegetarian dishes closely associated with UP's culinary identity

Continued on P4

Bihar portfolios: Samrat Home, Nishant Health



JD(U) leader Nishant Kumar takes oath during the oath-taking ceremony of ministers of the Bihar government at Gandhi Maidan, in Patna

PTI

MPOST BUREAU

PATNA: Portfolios were allocated on Thursday in the Bihar cabinet headed by Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, who kept the crucial home department with himself, while debutant Nishant Kumar, son of JD(U) president Nitish Kumar, got health.

According to a government notification issued hours after the cabinet expansion that took place in presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, among others, Choudhary has also retained portfolios like vigilance, cabinet secretariat, election, civil aviation and "all other departments not allocated to anybody else".

Earlier, after Choudhary succeeded Nitish Kumar last month, becoming the first BJP leader to head a government in

Continued on P4



DELHI REPORTS 64 CASES

# NCRB: Capital tops crimes against foreigners list across India in 2024

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded 64 cases of crimes against foreigners in 2024, the highest in India, and up from 63 in the previous year, according to the latest National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data.

The national capital reported 40 such cases in 2022, indicating a steady rise over the last three years.

The NCRB data, released on Wednesday, showed that Delhi accounted for almost the entire share of crimes against foreigners reported in union territories in 2024. Together, the UTs registered 67 such cases in the year, with Delhi alone contributing 64 cases.

Of the rest UTs, Jammu and Kashmir reported two cases, while the Andaman and Nicobar Islands recorded one case.

Chandigarh, which reported four cases in 2023, reported none in 2024.

The chargesheeting rate in Delhi stood at 46 per cent in 2024, lower than the national



**'Delhi accounted for almost the entire share of crimes against foreigners'**

average of 68 per cent.

The overall chargesheeting rate for Union Territories was 45.5 per cent. Across the country, 257 cases of crimes against foreigners were registered in 2024, compared to 238 in 2023 and 192 in 2022, the data showed.

Among states, Maharashtra reported 41 such cases, followed by Karnataka at 32, Himachal Pradesh at 19, Kerala at 17, Haryana at 16, and Goa at 13.

**'Delhi top metro in murders linked to love affairs, illicit relationships'**

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded the highest number of murders linked to illicit relationships and love affairs among metropolitan cities in 2024, according to the latest data released by the National Crime Records Bureau on Wednesday.

The national capital reported 11 murders committed over "love affairs" and 30 killings linked to "illicit relationships", the NCRB report said. Bengaluru ranked second among the 19 metropolitan cities with populations above 2 million, recording 11 murders related to love affairs and 19 linked to illicit relationships. Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai reported comparatively fewer such murders.

The report showed that disputes related to family,

property and money were the leading motives behind murders in Delhi. A total of 313 murders were reported under the "disputes" category, including 228 over "petty reasons", followed by 40 linked to money disputes and 30 to property disputes.

Delhi also recorded the highest number of murders motivated by dacoity, with 87 such killings in 2024. The city further topped the category of murders driven by "personal vendetta or enmity", reporting 81 cases. Surat followed with 49 such murders, ahead of Bengaluru (41), Ahmedabad (31), and Patna and Pune with 25 each. Nationally, 27,049 murder cases were registered in 2024, marking a decline of 2.4 per cent from 27,721 cases in 2023.

MP05T

**'Five Delhi Police personnel killed on duty in 2024'**

NEW DELHI: Five Delhi Police personnel were killed on duty in 2024, according to the latest NCRB data released by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs.

Two personnel were killed by criminals, gangsters or dacoits, while one died after accidentally firing a service/self weapon. Two others lost their lives in accidents during duty. Delhi recorded a total of five on-duty police deaths during the year, placing it among the Union territories with the highest such fatalities after Jammu and Kashmir, which reported nine deaths. Across the country, 283 uniformed police personnel were killed on duty in 2024.

MP05T

## Delhi Police arrest 482 in Operation Gang Bust 2.0

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Special Cell has arrested 482 people, including operatives linked to Pakistan's ISI-backed gangster networks, and raided 1,014 premises during "Operation Gang Bust 2.0", a pan-Delhi crackdown targeting organised crime syndicates and terror-linked criminal networks across Delhi, Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh.

The operation, conducted between 8 am on May 5 and 8 am on May 7, involved coordinated action by district police units and the Special Cell against gangsters, arms suppliers, financiers, social media handlers, shelter providers and other members of organised criminal networks operating in and around the national capital.

Police said the operation was an upgraded version of "Gang Bust 1.0", with intelligence-based targeting focused on dismantling both traditional organised crime syndicates and emerging terror-crime nexuses.

A major focus of the crackdown was the Pakistan-based ISI-linked Shahzad Bhatti network, which investigators



**'Members of the network were involved in installing IP-based CCTV cameras, conducting reconnaissance...'**

alleged was recruiting foot soldiers in India through social media platforms for anti-national activities.

According to police, members of the network were involved in installing IP-based CCTV cameras, conducting reconnaissance of sensitive locations, coordinating arms and narcotics deliveries, and carrying out targeted attacks.

Nine members of the network were arrested by the Special Cell, while 44 others linked to the syndicate were detained for preventive questioning and

disruption activities.

The arrested accused were identified as Shoyab Khan and Ravi Kashyap from Amroha in Uttar Pradesh, Anmol Rai from Tikamgarh in Madhya Pradesh, Imtiyaz Khan from Rajouri in Jammu and Kashmir, Rizwan Khan from Rampur in Uttar Pradesh, Jasbir Singh from Ferozepur, Jaskaran Singh from Moga, Satara Singh from Amritsar in Punjab, and Manoj from Banaskantha in Gujarat.

Police alleged that several accused had been tasked with carrying out random firing at security personnel in Delhi-NCR and north India, while others were allegedly involved in arms trafficking for the network.

The operation also led to the arrest of seven members of the Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu gang, four members each of the Sandeep Kala Jathedi and Saddam Gauri gangs, along with several operatives linked to other criminal syndicates.

During the raids, police seized 141 pistols, 212 cartridges, 79 knives, 24 vehicles, Rs 19 lakh in cash, 19 kilograms of narcotic substances, 31 mobile phones and 1,234 liquor quarters.

## Mother, daughter run over by train while crossing rly tracks

GURUGRAM: A mother-daughter duo was crushed to death by a train when they were crossing railway tracks at Garhi Harsaru Junction railway station in Gurugram on Thursday morning, said police.

After being hit by the train, the bodies of both severed into pieces, with some scattered about a hundred meters away, they added. According to the police, the deceased were identified as Mamta Devi (48), a resident of Bas Hariya village in Gurugram and her mother Madhubala (82), a resident of Ranila village in Charkhi Dadri district. According to family members, Madhubala had come to Bas Hariya village with her son Basant and daughter Babli to visit her married daughter Mamta.

They were scheduled to

catch a train to Jaipur on Thursday.

It was around 5 am when the mother-daughter duo came to Garhi-Harsaru railway station to go to Jaipur with their family. Family members said that Madhubala and Mamta were together, while the other three family members were walking at some distance.

Sampat Singh, a relative of the deceased, said that both were crossing the tracks to buy tickets when the Delhi-Sarai Rohilla Superfast was approaching on one track, while another train from Rewari was arriving on the adjacent track. Seeing the train from Rewari approaching, they stopped on one track, but failed to notice the Delhi-Sarai Rohilla Superfast coming on the other track.

MP05T

## DDA's largest hiring drive boosts workforce by 55% with over 1,600 fresh appointments

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major expansion of its administrative and operational capacity, the on Thursday handed over appointment letters to 1,647 newly recruited employees during a "Niyukti Samaroh" held in the national capital.

The ceremony was presided over by Taranjit Singh Sandhu, who also serves as the Chairman of the DDA. Addressing the newly appointed officers and staff, he urged them to work with "integrity, empathy and dedication" and emphasised that their role would be central to achieving the vision of a "Viksit Delhi" and "Viksit Bharat" by 2047.

Calling Delhi the "face of the country to the world", the Lieutenant Governor said public service must be viewed not merely as a profession but as



a responsibility towards citizens and urban transformation. He also highlighted the importance of transparent and merit-based recruitment in strengthening public institutions.

The recruitment drive, described by the Authority as its largest ever, has increased DDA's workforce from nearly 3,000 employees to around 4,650 an expansion of approximately 55 per cent. The appointments span 26 w posts

across Group A, B and C categories, including technical, administrative, engineering, planning and support services.

Among the major appointments are 745 Multi-Tasking Staff, 278 Malis, 147 Junior Secretariat Assistants, 104 Junior Engineers (Civil), 79 Patwaris and 75 Sectional Officers (Horticulture). Senior-level positions such as Deputy Directors, Assistant Directors and Assistant Executive Engineers have also been filled.

**“Among the major appointments are 745 Multi-Tasking Staff, 278 Malis, 147 Junior Secretariat Assistants, 104 Junior Engineers...”**

The DDA stated that the additional manpower would strengthen its capacity in urban planning, housing, infrastructure development and environmental projects. In recent years, the Authority has undertaken several flagship initiatives, including the rejuvenation of the Yamuna floodplains through projects such as Baansera and Asita, alongside large-scale housing and infrastructure developments in Narela, Dwarka and Rohini.

## Marijuana worth over Rs 24 cr seized at IGIA

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Customs officials at the Indira Gandhi International Airport here have seized suspected marijuana weighing over 24 kg and worth more than Rs 24 crore in three separate cases involving passengers arriving from Bangkok, officials said on Thursday.

In the biggest seizure, Customs officials apprehended an Uzbek national arriving from Bangkok on May 4 after acting on specific intelligence, an official statement said.

The passenger was off-loaded from the international transit area and subjected to a detailed examination, during which 12 polythene pouches containing suspected marijuana were recovered from a sea green trolley bag.

The seized substance

weighed over 18.003 kg and was valued at around Rs 18 crore, officials said.

The passenger was arrested on May 5 under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and the seized material was taken into custody. In another case, an Indian passenger arriving from Bangkok on May 6 was intercepted at the "Green Channel" on the basis of profiling and subjected to X-ray and detailed baggage examination.

Officials recovered 11 polythene pouches containing a green-coloured narcotic substance from a black trolley bag carried by the passenger.

Customs officials seized narcotic substances worth over Rs 6.43 crore in two separate cases at Delhi airport and arrested two passengers under the NDPS Act, officials said.

## AIIMS introduces AI smart glasses for visually impaired students

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In an effort to promote inclusive education and assistive healthcare, All India institute of medical science (AIIMS) has introduced AI-enabled smart vision glasses for visually impaired students in Delhi-NCR through its Dr. Rajendra Prasad Centre for Ophthalmic Sciences.

The initiative, launched in partnership with and Rotary members, aims to improve accessibility and independence for students with visual disabilities. The wearable devices use artificial intelligence to convert visual surroundings into audio instructions, helping users read text, recognise objects, identify currency notes and move around more confidently in public spaces. According to officials associated with the programme, nearly 1,700 visually impaired students across the region are expected to benefit from the initiative in phases. The smart glasses are being distributed after medical assessment and orientation sessions to ensure users can effectively adapt to the technology.

Doctors at Dr. Rajendra Prasad Centre for Ophthalmic Sciences said the AI-enabled smart glasses could improve mobility, independence and access to education for visually impaired students. AIIMS Delhi officials said the technology would also be studied for its long-term impact on learning, rehabilitation and social inclusion.

## Jyoti Baba gang member arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested a member of the Jyoti Baba gang, who was wanted in a murder case and had jumped the interim bail, from West Delhi, an official said on Thursday.

The accused, Rakesh alias Tinku (32), was apprehended after police laid a trap following a tip-off regarding his movements, he said.

Police said a court issued non-bailable warrants against Rakesh in an FIR related to murder, rioting and criminal intimidation.

"A team received input about his whereabouts on May



5. The accused allegedly tried to evade arrest but was overpowered. A semi-automatic Bretta pistol, along with two live cartridges, was recovered from his possession," said the police officer.

He said Rakesh, an active operative of the Jyoti Baba

gang, was wanted for the 2022 murder of Ram Niwas inside Tihar Jail.

He, along with another accused, Sachin alias Chhikara and their associates, allegedly killed Ram Niwas due to previous enmity.

Rakesh was first lodged in Tihar Jail in 2018 and later became associated with the Jyoti Baba gang.

Police records showed that the accused is involved in multiple criminal cases, including offences related to murder, attempt to murder, robbery, assault and illegal possession of arms.

Police said further investigation is underway.

## Stepfather held for raping minor

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man was arrested here for allegedly raping his 14-year-old stepdaughter, resulting in a five-month pregnancy, police said on Thursday.

According to the police, a PCR call regarding the matter was received on Wednesday. "Responding swiftly, a women's police team reached the spot and took the victim into a safe environment," a senior police officer said.

The officer further said that during preliminary inquiry, the victim disclosed that her stepfather had been subjecting her to forcible sexual intercourse

**A women's police team reached the spot and took the victim into a safe environment: Cops**

repeatedly for the last about one year, due to which she became pregnant.

"The accused is engaged in the work of manufacturing carton/cardboard boxes and was residing with the victim," the officer added.

The victim was immediately shifted to a hospital in the presence of women police staff, where the duty doctor confirmed sexual assault and

that the girl was approximately five months pregnant.

Based on the medical report and the victim's statement, a case under appropriate sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and the BNS was registered at Begumpur police station.

A dedicated police team launched a search operation and apprehended the accused from the Rohini area. During interrogation, it was confirmed that the accused was the victim's stepfather and had been living with her.

Further investigation in the case is in progress, said the police officer.

INDIGO TO OPERATE INAUGURAL LUCKNOW-NOIDA FLIGHT

## Noida Airport to begin commercial operations from Jun 15

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: Commercial operations at Noida International Airport are set to begin on June 15, with IndiGo launching the first scheduled flight connecting Lucknow to Noida. Officials said that ticket bookings for flights to and from the airport, which carries the IATA code DXN, opened on Thursday afternoon.

The inaugural flight, 6E 2278, will depart from Chaudhary Charan Singh International Airport Terminal 3 at 7:05 am and arrive at Noida International Airport at 8:05 am. The one-hour journey is currently priced at Rs 5,072 per seat on IndiGo's booking portal.

Soon after, the same aircraft will operate a Noida-Bengal-

**Ticket bookings open for flights from Noida**

uru service, departing at 8:35 am and reaching Bengaluru at 11:05 am. Besides these two flights, the inaugural day's schedule will also include an evening return service from Noida to Lucknow and a Bengaluru-Noida flight.

IndiGo plans to gradually expand operations from the airport. While most destinations will have daily connectivity, flights to Bareilly and Kishangarh are expected to operate on alternate days. The airline will initially connect Noida with 16 domestic destinations, including Lucknow, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Jammu, Navi Mumbai, Sri-

nagar, Jodhpur, Dharamshala, Bhopal, Dehradun, Bareilly, Kishangarh, Pantnagar, Jaipur and Chandigarh.

In a statement, IndiGo said the new services would strengthen regional and metro connectivity from western Uttar Pradesh and the National Capital Region (NCR). "Bookings for the flights are being progressively opened on IndiGo's official website, mobile app and authorised travel partners," the airline said.

Aloke Singh, Chief Strategy Officer, IndiGo, said the airline was proud to become the first carrier to commence operations from Noida International Airport, which will serve as the NCR's third commercial airport after Delhi's IGI Airport and Hindon. "Large metropolitan regions in India are

evolving to support multiple airports, and IndiGo is committed to providing affordable, on-time and hassle-free connectivity across this growing network," he said.

Shailendra Bhatia, additional CEO of the Yamuna Authority and nodal officer for NIAL, confirmed that Akasa Air and Air India Express are also expected to begin operations from June 16 or 17 after opening bookings in the coming days. He added that international flight services from Noida are likely to commence from September this year.

The airport recently received approval for its Aerodrome Security Program from the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security, clearing a key regulatory hurdle ahead of commercial launch.





250 MBBS SEATS PLANNED

# Delhi approves ₹806 crore medical college in Dwarka

AIMAN FATIMA

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi is set to get a major boost in health-care and medical education infrastructure, with the Rekha Gupta government approving an Rs 805.99-crore state-of-the-art medical college project at the Indira Gandhi Hospital campus in Dwarka. The ambitious project, cleared by the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, aims to make the national capital a leading hub for medical education while addressing the growing shortage of doctors and healthcare facilities.

The proposed institution will offer 250 MBBS seats annually and will begin academic activities with an initial batch of 150 students. Along with a modern academic block, the project will also include separate hostels for male and female students, faculty hous-



ing and other residential facilities. The Delhi government has set a target to complete the project by 2028.

Announcing the project, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "Making Delhi a hub of medical education is our goal." She described the initiative as a long-term investment in the capital's healthcare future and said it would significantly strengthen the city's medical

## TAKEAWAYS

- » Announcing the project, CM Gupta said, 'Making Delhi a hub of medical education is our goal'
- » She described the initiative as a long-term investment in the capital's healthcare future and said it would significantly strengthen the city's medical infrastructure

infrastructure.

According to officials, the project will be developed in phases. The first phase includes the construction of the academic block, student hostels and faculty residences across nearly 1,17,246 square metres, including about 34,000 square metres of basement area for parking and essential services. The academic complex will feature advanced classrooms,

» According to officials, the project will be developed in phases. The first phase includes the construction of the academic block, student hostels and faculty residences across nearly 1,17,246 square metres, including about 34,000 square metres of basement area for parking and essential services

laboratories and modern teaching infrastructure in line with National Medical Commission (NMC) norms.

The Chief Minister said the project would adopt sustainable and modern construction techniques. "The buildings will be earthquake-resistant and designed for energy efficiency," she said, adding that the campus would include solar power systems, rainwa-

ter harvesting, water recycling facilities and proper natural lighting and ventilation. The campus will also be fully accessible for persons with disabilities with ramps, lifts, Braille signage and wheelchair-friendly pathways.

Modern safety measures, including CCTV surveillance, fire alarms and fire safety systems, will be installed throughout the campus. The Public Works Department (PWD) will execute the construction work, while the Health and Family Welfare Department will supervise the project.

Directing officials to ensure timely completion, CM Rekha Gupta said, "Unnecessary delays and cost overruns will not be tolerated." She added that the institution would not only benefit Delhi residents but also cater to patients and students from neighbouring regions seeking quality health-care and medical education.

## Upgraded 'Jan Seva Connect' post office launched in Delhi

AIMAN FATIMA

**NEW DELHI:** Union Communications Minister Jyoti-raditya Scindia, along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Minister of State for Communications Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani, on Thursday inaugurated the redeveloped 'Jan Seva Connect' post office at Nehru Place as part of the Centre's nationwide postal modernisation campaign.

Addressing the gathering, Scindia described India Post as one of the country's most trusted institutions, playing a key role in financial inclusion and connectivity. "Just as arteries carrying blood sustain the human body, the Department of Posts serves and connects every corner of the nation," he said, praising the extensive postal network and the contribution of postal workers.

The Union Minister said the Department has invested nearly Rs.5,000 crore in upgrading its IT infrastructure and rolling out advanced postal technology. He highlighted reforms such as UPI-enabled services, OTP-based



delivery, 24x7 post offices and guaranteed delivery services including 24 Speed Post and 48 Speed Post in major metros.

Scindia also underlined the scale of India Post's operations, noting that it manages over 1.65 lakh post offices, delivers nearly 90 crore letters and 7.5 crore parcels annually, and operates more than 40 crore savings bank accounts with deposits exceeding Rs.23 lakh crore.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said it was a matter of pride that the campaign to redevelop 25,000 post offices

nationwide had begun in Delhi. "Post offices should emerge as modern public service hubs," she said, adding that they now provide banking, Aadhaar, passport and digital services under one roof.

She termed the Jan Seva Connect initiative a reflection of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of citizen-centric governance and said the modernisation of post offices would strengthen public outreach and improve citizen experience through technology-driven services.

## Parents association urges Delhi govt to intervene in school fee refund matter

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Delhi Parents Association (DPA) has urged Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Education Minister Ashish Sood to intervene in the long-pending school fee refund matter linked to the recommendations of the Justice Anil Dev Singh Committee, claiming dues of over Rs 1,317 crore.

In a memorandum submitted to the Delhi government on Thursday, the association sought disclosure of all schools liable for refunds and requested strong representation before the Delhi High Court, which is scheduled to hear the matter on May 8.

The Justice Anil Dev Singh Committee was constituted to examine alleged unjustified fee hikes by private unaided schools in the national capital and had identified several schools for refund of excess fees collected from parents.

According to the association, a public list of around 531 schools covered under the committee's recommendations was released in 2016, but the committee is understood to have continued functioning till around April 2020.

The DPA alleged that the publicly available list may not represent the complete and final list of schools covered under the committee's work.

## KEY POINTS

- » DPA alleged that the publicly available list may not represent the complete & final list of schools covered under the committee's work
- » It claimed that nearly 230 schools had challenged the committee's findings before courts, while around 300 schools may still remain liable for refunds without having challenged the recommendation

It claimed that nearly 230 schools had challenged the committee's findings before courts, while around 300 schools may still remain liable for refunds without having challenged the recommendations.

The association also raised concerns that some schools may fall outside both the publicly available list and the known list of schools that approached courts, creating ambiguity over the total number of refund-liable schools and the overall refund amount.

Parents' group seeks transparent refund process in school fee case, says liability may cross Rs 1,317 crore by 2026.

## Delhi to get 13 new CAAQMS this yr; ten DPCC stns likely operational by October

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi will get 13 more Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring Stations (CAAQMS) this year, with the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) working on 10 of these stations, which are expected to be functional by October, a senior DPCC official said on Thursday.

The official said Delhi currently has the highest number of air quality monitoring stations among all cities in the country, as well as the highest density of CAAQMS.

"Currently, Delhi has 47 CAAQMS, with plans to set up 13 more. DPCC is working on plans for 10 of the air quality monitoring stations," the senior official stated.

Another official said, "DPCC is also developing a supersite that will collect in-depth data."

'Of Delhi's current total stations, 30 are operated by the DPCC, seven by IMD, three by IITM...'

The remaining three stations, according to the official, will be undertaken by the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM) and are expected to be operational around July. However, the locations of the new CAAQMS are yet to be finalised.

Earlier this year, in February, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated six new CAAQMS. She said the government is working to ensure that for every 25 sq km of area in Delhi, there is at least one air quality monitoring station to provide complete and accurate data on pollution levels as well as sources.

Of Delhi's current total stations, 30 are operated by the DPCC,

seven by the India Meteorological Department (IMD), three by IITM, six by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and one by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA).

Meanwhile, Delhi's Public Accounts (PAC), in its third report of the eighth assembly, presented in March 2026, examined the Comptroller and Auditor General's performance audit of "Prevention and Mitigation of Vehicular Air Pollution in Delhi for the year ended 31 March, 2021," and observed that several CAAQMS did not fully comply with the siting guidelines prescribed by the CPCB.

The Committee further recommended that the Environment Department strictly comply with CPCB siting guidelines and remove obstacles or suitably address deficiencies wherever identified, ensuring that monitoring stations generate reliable air quality data. The report also mentioned that in 2022, a joint committee of the DPCC and CPCB assessed the siting criteria for monitoring stations and found most stations compliant with CPCB guidelines.

"Although three stations (Anand Vihar, RK Puram and Jahangir Puri) had siting concerns, the CAQM decided not to shift them, considering their location in densely populated and highly polluted areas and the need to maintain continuity of long-term data," the Environment Department's action taken report mentioned.

## Ambulance blaze triggers cylinder blast; no injuries

**NEW DELHI:** A CAT ambulance of Safdarjung Hospital caught fire near the Moti Bagh flyover in southwest Delhi on Thursday evening, triggering an oxygen cylinder blast inside the vehicle, police said.

No injuries were reported. The ambulance was returning after dropping a patient in Samalkha when the fire broke out around 7.20 pm, reportedly due to a short circuit. A nearby motorcycle was completely gutted. Two fire tenders doused the blaze.

MPOST

## Standing Committee's six vacant seats likely to be filled this month

**NEW DELHI:** The Municipal Corporation of Delhi's 18-member standing committee is likely to fill six vacant seats in the upcoming weeks, officials said on Thursday.

The standing committee has 18 members and serves as the top executive and decision-making body of the corporation. It handles key financial functions, approves projects and plays a central role in shaping, finalising and implementing policies for the city.

According to officials, the remaining six vacant seats on the standing committee will be filled through elections from the zonal ward committees in the meeting, which is likely to be held in the third or fourth week of May. Nine members retired after a draw of lots conducted on March 31, they added.

On April 29, Jai Bhagwan Yadav from Begumpur and Manish Chadha from Paharganj were elected to the standing committee from the

BJP, while AAP councillor Jalaj Chaudhary from Shalimar Bagh was also elected to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) panel, taking the tally of the panel to 12.

Out of 18, six are elected from the MCD house and 12 from each zonal ward committee. Under MCD rules, each standing committee member has a two-year term, but after the first year, half the members retire through a draw of lots.

Officials said the draw

of lots process is carried out only once during the five-year tenure of the corporation, at the end of the first year of the standing committee. At the end of the next financial year, the remaining nine members will automatically retire.

According to the outcome in March 31 meeting, six ward committee members and three house members were excluded by the draw. Of these, six members belong to the BJP and three to AAP.

AGENCIES

## Forest dept to plant 5L saplings across city

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Delhi forest department is planning a mega plantation drive in June to plant around five lakh saplings across the capital as part of the Green Action Plan aimed at increasing the city's green cover.

Officials said 1,060 plantation sites had been identified across Delhi till May 7, including roadsides, institutional premises, vacant public spaces and other suitable locations.

Native and environment-friendly species are likely to be prioritised to ensure better adaptability to Delhi's climate and long-term ecological benefits.

A centralised "green war room" will also be established to monitor plantation work in real time, coordinate among agencies and track sapling survival rates.

Under the Green Action Plan, the overall plantation target for the season has been fixed at 70 lakh saplings, including 20 lakh to be distributed free to residents.

## Delhi rolls out awareness drive for Census '27 with mobile vans

9.2 million households complete self-enumeration nationwide

NARESH BISWANI

**NEW DELHI:** The Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India on Thursday flagged off six awareness vans from Jangana Bhawan to encourage public participation in Census 2027 across the national capital.

The mobile awareness units will travel across Delhi to disseminate information on census procedures and encourage participation in the upcoming door-to-door surveys. The exercise forms part of the initial phase of Census 2027, officially termed the Houselisting and Housing Census (HLO).

Officials said the campaign also highlights the newly introduced self-enumeration facility, allowing residents to submit their census details online. The awareness drive is aimed at ensuring wider public outreach ahead of the large-scale field exercise.

From May 1 to May 15, 2026, residents in areas under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi are undertaking self-enumeration through the national



census portal. Door-to-door visits by census officials in these areas will commence from June 16, after the online self-reporting phase concludes.

In areas under the New Delhi Municipal Council and the Delhi Cantonment Board, self-enumeration is also being carried out till May 15, following which enumerator teams will begin field verification and household visits in a phased manner.

Officials said over 9.2 million households across 23 regions nationwide have completed self-enumeration so far.

'During field operations, officials will collect information on housing conditions, amenities, assets and living standards...'

The online submission facility has been introduced for the first time in the country's census process.

During field operations, officials will collect information on housing conditions, amenities, assets and living standards through a 33-point questionnaire.

Authorities reiterated that all information collected under the Census Act, 1948, remains confidential and will be used solely for statistical analysis and planning purposes, without disclosing individual details to any outside party.

OVER 12 CR HOUSEHOLD INSPECTIONS CONDUCTED

## MCD intensifies anti-mosquito drive after Delhi sees spike in dengue cases

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) said on Thursday that it has intensified its anti-mosquito drive across the city following unusually high rainfall in April, with over 12 crore household inspections carried out in a month to check the spread of vector-borne diseases.

According to the civic body, around 4,100 MTS employees of the Public Health Department conducted 121.5 lakh household visits between April 1 and April 30 to inspect for mosquito breeding.

This year, the national capital witnessed a spike in dengue cases, as according to the MCD's official data, Delhi has recorded 107 dengue cases so far this year, of which 52 were reported in April alone.

In comparison, the city had logged 130 dengue cases till April in 2025, including 32 cases in April. Similarly, 35 cases in April 2024 and 18 in April 2023.

Officials said anti-mosquito insecticide was sprayed



in 79,298 homes, while larvivoracious fish were released at 231 sites to control mosquito larvae in water bodies. The MCD said its teams are carrying out weekly anti-larval spraying in drains, stagnant water bodies and other vulnerable locations.

Special inspection drives were also conducted at construction sites, schools, residential colonies, drains and police maalkhanas, considered vulnerable to mosquito breeding. Eight such campaigns have been organised so far, the official statement read.

Under the provisions of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act and vector-borne disease bye-laws, the civic body issued 16,261 legal notices

and imposed 856 challans where mosquito breeding was detected, officials said.

The corporation said it has also stepped up public outreach measures, with officials holding 3,582 resident welfare association meetings and organising 1,392 rallies to spread awareness about dengue, malaria and chikungunya prevention.

Besides this, 7,002 stickers and 1,792 banners were put up across the city, while WhatsApp groups have been created in every ward to address complaints related to mosquito breeding, it said.

The civic body said the city recorded 30 mm rainfall in April this year, the highest for the month in the last 18 years,

The MCD said adequate stocks of anti-larval & anti-mosquito chemicals are available with the Public Health Department

compared to only 0.7 mm rainfall recorded in April 2025.

Officials said intermittent rainfall and water accumulation have created favourable conditions for mosquito breeding, prompting intensified surveillance and fogging operations.

The MCD said adequate stocks of anti-larval and anti-mosquito chemicals are available with the Public Health Department.

The civic body appealed to residents not to allow water stagnation in and around their homes and advised them to cover water containers, keep tanks sealed and clean water coolers at least once every week.



# UP govt’s veg-only cuisine...

**Continued from Page 1**

Among the notable omissions are Lucknow’s famed Tunday and Galouti kebabs, Awadhi biryani and nihari, Rampur’s mutton korma and seekh kebabs, and Bareilly’s well-known mutton preparations. Food enthusiasts have also pointed out that cities such as Varanasi and Prayagraj, known for distinctive non-vegetarian street foods and curries, have been represented only through vegetarian offerings.

The absence of these dishes has triggered debate among food historians and culinary experts, many of whom argue that the list presents an incomplete picture of state’s food culture.

Food historian and Cuisine Society of India President Pushpesh Pant criticised the ODOC list for featuring only vegetarian dishes, calling the approach “half baked”. Speaking to reporters, Pant said the move reflected a biased outlook and described it as “ignorant nonsense”. While making it clear that he had no objection to promoting vegetarian cuisine, he questioned why the state appeared to be selectively excluding non-vegetarian culinary traditions.

State Cabinet minister Rakesh Sachan, however, denied that the exclusion of non-vegetarian dishes

was deliberate. “It is not intentional. If recommended in the future, they can be added. The idea is not to promote individual popular items but dishes that benefit a larger population through packaging, sales and promotion,” Sachan told The Indian Express.

He said the list remains flexible and can be revised on the basis of local recommendations and public demand.

“The scheme has been approved by the Cabinet, but the list of cuisines can be changed any time based on local recommendations and public demand, with approval from the Chief Minister. It does not require Cabinet approval,” he said.

According to the ODOC list, Agra has been identified with petha and dalmoth, while Firozabad is associated with potato-based dishes such as tikki and kachori. Mainpuri features sohan papdi and boiled potato preparations, and Mathura is recognised for peda, khurchan and mishri-based sweets.

Aligarh has been tagged with dairy products and kachori, Hathras with hing-linked items and khurchan, while Kasganj is associated with moong dal halwa and singhada flour snacks.

In central Uttar Pradesh, Ayodhya’s kachori, peda and kulhad dahilebji, Sultanpur’s peda and savoury

items, Barabanki’s chandrakala, and Amethi’s samosa and jaggery sweets have been included. Ambedkar Nagar is known for batasha and khoya-based preparations.

Eastern Uttar Pradesh also figures prominently in the list. Azamgarh is associated with theeri and carrot halwa, Ballia with sattu-based dishes, and Mau with litti-chokha. Varanasi’s entries include tiranga barfi, than-dai, lassi, kachori and Banarasi paan, while Jaunpur is known for imarti and traditional sweets. In western Uttar Pradesh, Meerut’s revdi and gajak, Ghaziabad’s papad-based preparations, Gautam Buddha Nagar’s bakery products, Hapur’s papad, and Bulandshahr’s kachori and peda have been included. Baghpat has been associated with balushahi and ghevar.

Other districts on the list include Prayagraj for kachori, samosa and ras-malai, Fatehpur for bedmi puri and sweets, Kaushambi for jaggery-based products, and Pratapgarh for amla-based items. Saharanpur is known for honey products, Muzaffarnagar for jaggery sweets, and Shamli for jaggery-based snacks.

Officials said the ODOC initiative aims to systematically catalogue and promote local cuisines across the state while boosting employment and entrepreneurship.

## TCS case: Accused Nida Khan held in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

**NASHIK:** Nashik TCS sexual harassment and religious coercion case accused Nida Khan was held on Thursday in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, a police official said here.

She was held with the help of Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar police and the crime branch of that city, Nashik police commissioner Sandeep Karnik informed.

Khan is an accused in the Deolali Camp police station crime register number 156/26 here, he said.

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Nashik police is probing nine cases of molestation and harassment at the IT major’s Nashik unit.

It had arrested eight persons, including a female operations manager, by registering nine FIRs after allegations of exploitation, attempt of forceful conversion, hurting religious sentiments, molestation and mental harassment of female employees at the TCS unit came to light.

The SIT had launched a search for Khan in different parts of Maharashtra. She is accused of targeting employees in a WhatsApp group, pressuring them to pray and eat non-vegetarian food. According to the FIR, Khan allegedly advised women employees to dress and behave in accordance with Islamic traditions.

## Manipur: Armed militants torch houses in Kamjong, residents flee

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**IMPHAL:** Heavily armed militants attacked villages in Manipur’s Kamjong district near the India-Myanmar border on Thursday morning, torching houses and forcing residents to flee, officials said.

According to police, the militants attacked the Tangkhul Naga villages of Namlee, Wanglee and Choro within Kasom Khullen police station area around 4 am, prompting residents of the border settlements to take shelter in nearby forests.

The villages are located less than a kilometre from the international border.

At least one elderly woman sustained injuries while attempting to flee during the attack, officials said.

According to villagers, two houses in Namlee, three to four houses in Wanglee and several houses in Choro, except for a church, were reduced to ashes.

Security forces, including the Assam Rifles, later reached the area to assess the situation.

### At least one elderly woman sustained injuries while attempting to flee during the attack, officials said

Phungyar MLA L Keishing alleged that the attack was carried out from across the border by Myanmar-based militant groups Kuki National Army (Burma) and the People’s Defence Force (PDF).

“So far, the state had been seeing internal conflicts, but today there has been external aggression. A combined force of Kuki National Army-B and People’s Defence Force attacked four to five border villages at 3.30 am,” Keishing told reporters.

“Several houses have been reduced to ashes, though there have been no fatalities. Two persons, including a woman, remain untraceable. Eyewitnesses said they were taken away by the armed militants,” the Naga People’s Front legis-

lator claimed.

Calling it an “external aggression”, the MLA said both the state and central governments should not remain silent.

“There is no presence of Manipur Police in the area,” he alleged.

Keishing accused the Assam Rifles of failing to protect the villages.

“Assam Rifles troops visited the villages yesterday, and the attack happened today. Villagers have expressed frustration over the developments,” he said.

Meanwhile, former chief minister N Biren Singh claimed that the attack on the border villages was an act of cross-border terrorism carried out by forces from across the Indo-Myanmar border.

“Our indigenous communities continue to face this grave threat from a continued external aggression. Unless this issue is effectively tackled with firm resolve & strengthened border security, peace will continue to elude our state,” he said in a post on X.

## From Page 1 DMK says

risking the victory achieved through the hard work of its coalition members,” the resolution said.

“The Congress has committed a great betrayal by stabbing our party leader in the back, not even coming in person to thank him for the victory. But he (Stalin) showed tolerance and acted with generosity and responsibility,” it said.

Another resolution thanked the people of Tamil Nadu, and allies for voting for the combine while another thanked Stalin for protecting the DMK, TN, and for developing the state in the past five years.

Yet another resolution unanimously authorised Stalin to take all necessary immediate political decisions.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## TVK shops

wanted the governor to invite TVK to form government. They are likely to extend support, considering Vijay is open to accommodate prospective allies in his cabinet.

Vijay, based on an invite from governor Arlekar, visited the Lok Bhavan in his second visit within 24 hours.

“During the meeting, the Hon’ble Governor explained that the requisite majority support in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, essential for forming the government, has not been established,” Lok Bhavan said in a press release.

CPI State Secretary Veerapandian said a decision was likely on Friday and VCK top leader Thol Thirumavalavan said his party’s top level body would decide on the matter after Left parties take a stand on the issue of extending support to TVK, which is five short of the required 118 MLAs to install its first government.

The Congress, Left parties and VCK chief Thirumavalavan also condemned the Governor for not inviting Vijay so far to form the government.

“Experts say that the governor cannot demand a list of 118 MLAs who will support the government and our view is that the BJP is creating confusion in Tamil Nadu politics. They may be asked to prove majority on the floor of the House and they cannot be asked to give list in advance,” Thirumavalavan told reporters.

TNCC announced a state-wide protest against the Governor and BJP regime at the Centre over the issue on Friday.

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee in a statement said, “Governments are not decided on the lawns of Lok Bhavan. They are decided on the floor of the House.”

TVK leader CTR Nirmal Kumar called on Veerapandian and Marxist party leader Shanmugam and sought their support in forming a government and told reporters that they had also requested IUML to extend its support.

Meanwhile, DMK sources said party president and outgoing Chief Minister MK Stalin conveyed his wish --in a meeting-- to the leaders of alliance parties including the Left that they should continue to be part of the Secular Progressive Alliance.

On the AIADMK front, MLAs of the party were lodged in a resort in neighbouring Pudukchery.

CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby called upon Arlekar to uphold democratic conventions by inviting the TVK to form the government as it was the single largest party in a fractured assembly.

Speaking on the political impasse in Tamil Nadu, the CPI (M) top leader argued that in the absence of a clear majority or a pre-poll alliance reaching the magic number, constitutional precedent dictates that the leader of the largest party be sworn in. He cited the 1996 invitation to BJP stalwart Atal Bihari Vajpayee as a historical parallel.

Meanwhile, TVK cadres staged a protest demonstration outside the Lok Bhavan on Thursday, demanding that the governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar should allow the party chief Vijay to form the government.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## Op Sindoor

armed forces to conduct multi-domain operations, a capability created through jointness, integration and capability-building in the new domains of warfare. We dominated the enemy in all domains and dimensions of the conflict.”

Operation Sindoor also demonstrated superior situation awareness at every level of escalation, General Chauhan said.

The documentary was released at a joint press conference by the heads of military operations of the Indian Air Force, Navy, and Army in Jaipur on the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor.

“Operation Sindoor was not the end. It was just the beginning,” Lieutenant General Rajiv Ghai, who played a key role in executing the operation in his capacity as the Army’s Director General of Military Operations (DGMO), said.

No terror sanctuary across the Line of Control is safe, and India will target every terrorist infrastructure at a time and manner of its choosing, the Indian military said, sending a clear warning to Pakistan.

“No sanctuary across the Line of Control is safe. We will hit everything. We will go after everything and that has been made clear in the new normal that the prime minister said last year. But the conditions, the timing and the method will be ours,” said Lt Gen Rajiv Ghai, Deputy Chief of Army Staff (strategy).

The timing and method for targeting terror infrastructure will remain at the Indian military’s discretion, he said.

“Operation Sindoor was not an end and it was just the beginning,” Lt Gen Ghai, currently serving as the Deputy Chief of Army Staff (Strategy), said.

In response to the Pahalgam terror attack, India launched Operation Sindoor on May 7 last year carrying out airstrikes on nine terror infrastructures in Pakistan and Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir eliminating at least 100 terrorists.

“In an era of prolonged conflicts around the world, we struck hard, achieved clearly defined objectives and then decided to cease hostilities when the Pakistanis were compelled to negotiate and requested us to stop,” he said.

Lt Gen Ghai said the Operation Sindoor showcased capabilities of India’s indigenous weapon systems and platforms and made a mention of BrahMos and Akash, missiles, homegrown surveillance and targeting systems and ammunition.

In his remarks, Air Marshal A

K Bharti, who too played a crucial role as Director General of Air Operations in implementation of Operation Sindoor, highlighted the “primacy of air power” in achieving desired results.

He said India’s military might is being strengthened significantly and that the India Air Force has been constantly monitoring the activities of China and Pakistan.

Air Marshal Bharti, currently serving as Deputy Chief of the IAF, however, did not mention about losses of assets by his force.

Director General of Naval Operations Vice Admiral AN Pramod said Operation Sindoor underscored the strategic vision of India’s approach in combating terrorism.

He said the forward deployment of the Indian Navy assets compelled Pakistani naval and air units to enter in a defensive posture and it largely confined the Pakistani Navy to harbours.

“Operation Sindoor validated India’s ability to respond to asymmetric provocation with deliberate, precise and proportionate force. It demonstrated that terror infrastructure and supporting military enablers can be targeted swiftly and effectively,” he said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## Assam BJP-led

Union minister J P Nadda and Naib Singh Saini have been appointed as the observer and co-observer, respectively, for the election of the BJP Legislature party leader, which is likely to be held on May 10.

The ruling NDA returned to power for the third successive term, securing 102 of the 126 Assembly seats in the state with the BJP winning 82 constituencies and its allies - the Bodoland People’s Front (BPF) and the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) - bagging 10 each.

## Bihar portfolios

Bihar, speculations were rife that the JD(U) would insist on ‘getting back’ the Home portfolio, which controls the state police.

During his two-decade-long rule, Kumar had kept the Home portfolio with himself but yielded to the BJP’s demand in November last year when it was allocated to Choudhary, who was then his deputy.

Nishant Kumar, 45, who joined the JD(U) less than two months ago and is yet to become a member of the state legislature, has been given the opportunity to prove his mettle by the allocation of the health department.

The department has, for past many years, been with former state BJP president Mangal Pandey, who was not included in the expanded cabinet, giving rise to speculations that he may be given a “big responsibility” in the party.

Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Chaudhary, a senior JD(U) leader, has retained water resources and parliamentary affairs while his party colleague and fellow Deputy CM Bijendra Prasad Yadav will continue to handle finance and commercial tax.

Shrawon Kumar, a key aide of Nitish Kumar, has been given rural development and information and public relations department, while Leshi Singh, another confidant of

the JD(U) supremo, has got building construction.

Senior BJP leader Vijay Kumar Sinha, who was formerly a Deputy CM, has been given agriculture while the party’s former state unit president Dilip Jaiswal has got revenue and land reforms.

BJP’s Shreyasi Singh, who was formerly an award-winning shooter, has got sports and industry while her party colleague Rama Nishad has been given Welfare of Other Backward Classes and Extremely Backward Classes department.

Education is now likely to bear the BJP’s stamp in the state with the department going to Mithilesh Tiwari, while his party colleague Sanjay Singh Tiger has got higher education and law.

JD(U) leader Zama Khan, the sole Muslim in the 35-strong cabinet, has got minority affairs while his party colleague Madan Sahni has been given prohibition, a key portfolio in the dry state.

Shailesh Kumar alias Bulu Mandal, a former RJD MP who joined the JD(U) months ahead of last year’s Assembly polls, will handle power, while Ashok Choudhary, a former Congress heavyweight and one of the most trusted aides of Nitish Kumar since joining the JD(U) eight years ago, has been assigned food and consumer affairs.

BJP’s Dalit face in Bihar Lakshendra Paswan has got SC and ST welfare while Santosh Suman, the son of Union minister Jitan Ram Manjhi, the Hindustani Awam Morcha’s representative in the cabinet, will look after minor irrigation.

Ratnesh Sada and Sunil Kumar, both Dalit leaders from JD(U), have been assigned disaster management and rural works, respectively.

JD(U) veteran Damodar Rawat and greenhorn Shweta Gupta, both of whom made it to the cabinet for the first time, have got transport and social welfare, respectively.

Sanjay Kumar Singh and Sanjay Kumar Paswan, both from Union minister Chirag Paswan’s LJPRV, have been assigned public health engineering department and sugarcane, respectively.

Former Union minister Upendra Kushwaha’s son Deepak Prakash, who is yet to be elected to the state legislature, has been given Panchayati Raj.

BJP MLC Pramod Kumar Chandravanshi has got mining and geology and art and culture while his party colleague Kedar Prasad Gupta has been allocated tourism.

The BJP has retained road construction department and it has been allocated to Kumar Shaileन्द्रa while the party’s Arun Shankar Prasad is in charge of labour resources and youth, employment and skill development.

BJP’s Nitish Mishra, who in the past won laurels by organising investment summits in his capacity as industry minister, will now take care of urban development and housing and Information Technology.

Science, Technology and Technical Education have gone to JD(U) leader Sheela Mandal.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## Police form SIT

officers from the state Criminal Investigation Department (CID), state police Special Task Force (STF) and Intelligence Branch (IB), will be headed by the Inspector General (IG), CID.

The police have got CCTV footage where a motorcycle was spotted

with two suspects riding it, a few minutes after the shootout.

In another CCTV footage, Rath’s vehicle was spotted moving along a narrow lane moments before the shootout. Reportedly, cops are checking more CCTV footage to ascertain the escape route of the criminals.

“Going by the circumstantial evidence, it seems that the murder was pre-planned. Investigators are examining CCTV footage from the crime spot and nearby areas, while multiple police teams have been formed to trace the assailants,” an officer said.

On Wednesday night, Director General of Police (DGP) of West Bengal, Siddh Nath Gupta, along with the Additional Director General of Police (ADGP), Law and Order, Ajey Mukund Ranade, visited the hospital where Rath was declared brought dead. After interacting with the senior officials of the Barasat Police District, DGP had said: “We have started an investigation. A car that was used in the crime has been seized. We have come to know that the car number plate was false and tampered with. Also, from the spot, fired cartridges and live rounds were seized as well.”

It has been learnt that the number attached to the car used in the murder is originally from another car owned by a man in Siliguri.

The owner of the original vehicle, identified as William Joseph, is originally from Kerala but has been residing in a rented house near Siliguri Shiv Mandir’s Haler Math area for several years. Interestingly, the actual vehicle remains with him. Following the lead, cops from Matigara police station reached his residence and brought him in for questioning.

During interrogation in the presence of the Commissioner of Police (CP), Siliguri Metropolitan Police, Syed Waqar Raza, Joseph reportedly informed police that around two weeks ago, he had uploaded photographs of his car on an online site attempting to sell the vehicle. The pictures displayed the registration number clearly. It is suspected that the accused persons copied the registration number from those online photographs and used it in a similar-looking vehicle during the crime.

Meanwhile, on Thursday morning, a forensic team visited the murder spot and collected samples. A CID team also visited the spot after the forensic visit was completed. It has been learnt that the police have detained a few persons on suspicion of their involvement in the crime. However, till Thursday evening, no arrest was made.

On Thursday afternoon, after the autopsy, Rath’s body was taken to his residence in Chandipur of East Midnapore, where thousands of people, including BJP leaders and workers, along with common people, gathered to pay respect before the final rites. Meanwhile, Rath’s driver, who was admitted to a private hospital on EM Bypass near Kadapura, had undergone a critical surgery. Three bullets were taken out of his body. Sources informed that his condition is stable but has been kept under observation.

Meanwhile, the incident has also triggered political tension. The state BJP president, Samik Bhattacharya, on Thursday described the murder of Rath as a “planned political murder” and claimed that it was aimed at creating instability in the state ahead of Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi’s visit to Kolkata.

Speaking to reporters at the Barasat Hospital, where the post-

mortem of Rath was carried out, Bhattacharya said that it was a targeted violence unleashed to take revenge. “We can speak in the same language as TMC speaks. But we will not do it,” he stated.

Trinamool Congress, on the other hand, condemned the incident and demanded a court-monitored CBI probe.

“We strongly condemn the brutal murder of Chandranath Rath in Madhyamgram tonight, along with the killing of three other TMC workers in incidents of post-poll violence allegedly carried out by BJP-backed miscreants over the last three days, despite the Model Code of Conduct being in force.

We demand the strongest possible action in this matter, including a court-monitored CBI investigation so that those responsible are identified and brought to justice without delay. Violence and political killings have no place in a democracy and the guilty must be held accountable at the earliest,” TMC posted on its social media.

Meanwhile, the mortal remains of Rath were consigned to flames in his native village in East Midnapore district on Thursday, as thousands of villagers mourned his death.

Rath’s body, a former Indian Air Force employee, was draped in the national flag when it was kept on a field in his village, Kulup, for the people to pay their tribute. Several BJP leaders, including Dibyendu Adhikari, brother of Suvendu, were present there.

## Shah to chair

scheduled to be held in the presence of PM Modi on May 9.

In his presence, the BJP’s newly elected MLAs will choose their legislative party leader. Shah is also expected to attend the swearing-in ceremony on Saturday.

The Home Ministry has officially released Amit Shah’s schedule. It confirms he is on a two-day visit to West Bengal, arriving on Friday. He will fly back to Delhi right after the BJP’s swearing-in ceremony on Saturday.

According to the Union Home Minister’s official schedule, he will leave his Krishna Menon Marg residence at 10:15 am on Friday. He will then head to Delhi’s Palam airport. His flight to Kolkata is at 10:40 am, with a landing time of 12:40 pm. Shah will reach the hotel in New Town around 1 pm.

After reaching at 1 pm and taking a short break, Shah will get into meetings with party leaders and workers to select the legislative party head. These discussions could go on till 8 pm.

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi will also be accompanying Shah on this visit. Shah was appointed as the BJP’s central observer with Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi serving as co-observer.

Amid growing speculation, Suvendu Adhikari has emerged as the frontrunner for the chief minister’s post ahead of the legislature party meeting scheduled for May 8.

Sources within the BJP said that the possibility of a tribal face is also being considered alongside the names of Adhikari and others, as the BJP has secured 38 out of the 40 Assembly seats in the Jangalmahal region.

Apart from Adhikari, names such as state BJP president Samik

Bhattacharya, Union minister Sukanta Majumdar and former Rajya Sabha MP Swapan Dasgupta have surfaced in political discussions.

The rise of Adhikari carries with it layers of political irony unique to Bengal politics.

The man who once stood beside Mamata Banerjee during the Nandigram land agitation that dismantled the Left Front’s 34-year rule is now positioned at the centre of the BJP’s own “poribartan” moment against the very party he helped build.

For many in the BJP, that political arc has become emblematic of the changing grammar of Bengal politics itself.

“I was part of the 2011 ‘poribartan’, and now I am part of the real change,” he told supporters, while announcing that he would vacate one of the two seats within 10 days after consultations with the party leadership.

Sources said that Shah will leave his New Town hotel at 10:35 am on Saturday and is expected to arrive at the Brigade Parade Ground by 10:55 am.

The BJP’s swearing-in ceremony on Saturday is expected to wrap up by 12:20 pm. He will depart from Brigade at 12:20 pm and head straight to Kolkata airport for his 12:45 pm flight back to Delhi.

Over the last decade, the BJP has steadily attempted to reinterpret Bengal’s icons — from Tagore and Swami Vivekananda to Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose and Syama Prasad Mookerjee — as part of a broader ideological effort to expand its emotional footprint beyond traditional electoral polarisation.

Yet beneath the triumphalism, the BJP leadership remains conscious of the volatile atmosphere accompanying the transition of power.

However, the killing of Adhikari’s aide Chandranath Rath in North 24-Parganas this week has cast a shadow over the celebrations, sharpening the political acrimony that has marked Bengal’s post-poll landscape.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath’s adviser Awanish Awasthi highlighted the initiative in a post on X on Tuesday, saying Uttar Pradesh would seek to give global recognition to its traditional dishes through modern branding and improved packaging.

“This step will empower local artisans while giving a boost to employment and entrepreneurship. Under the leadership of the chief minister, Uttar Pradesh is creating a new identity in taste, culture and economy,” Awasthi said.

The initiative was also highlighted by Chief Minister Adityanath during discussions on the 2026-27 Budget in the state assembly on February 20.

Drawing parallels with the successful ‘One District One Product’ model, the chief minister said the scheme envisages focused efforts on quality improvement, packaging, branding, marketing and training for traditional food items.

He cited examples such as Meerut’s revdi and gajak, Hathras’s hing, Hapur’s papad, Prayagraj’s guava, Ballia’s halwa and Jaunpur’s imarti as products that would receive a new identity under the scheme.

Officials said the broader objective of the ODOC initiative is to encourage skill development, attract investment, strengthen branding of local cuisines and generate employment, positioning Uttar Pradesh as a hub of culinary entrepreneurship.



'ALL ILLEGAL FOREIGN NATIONALS STAYING MUST BE REPATRIATED'

# India urges B'desh to fast-track nationality check of 3K immigrants

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Thursday conveyed to Bangladesh to expedite the nationality verification of nearly 3,000 suspected illegal Bangladeshi immigrants, days after Dhaka said it will take action if New Delhi forcibly pushes any such individuals.

New Delhi's comments came against the backdrop of a social media post by Bangladesh's Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman on the issue on Tuesday in which he said Dhaka will take action if there any "push-in" incidents from the Indian side.

"These comments must be seen in the context of the core issue of repatriation of illegal Bangladeshis from India. This requires cooperation from Bangladesh." External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said. "Over 2862 cases of nationality veri-



BSF thwarts large-scale attempt by Bangladeshis to enter India from Cooch Behar border

## Highlights

» The issue of illegal migration from Bangladesh came to fore during the campaigning for the assembly election in West Bengal

» Jaiswal also responded to another question on possible cooperation between Bangladesh and China on the management of the Teesta river

» "We expect Bangladesh to expedite nationality verification so that repatriation of illegal immigrants can take place in a smooth manner," he said

The Trinamool Congress had trashed the charges.

Jaiswal also responded to another question on possible cooperation between Bangladesh and China on the management of the Teesta river.

"Between India and Bangladesh, we have 54 rivers that the two countries share. We have structured bilateral mechanisms to discuss all water-related issues. These bilateral mechanisms continue to meet at regular intervals," he said.

Bangladesh's state-run BSS news agency reported on Thursday that Foreign Minister Rahman, during his ongoing visit to China, had sought Beijing's involvement and support for the Teesta river restoration project. The issues concerning the Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project (TRCMRP) were discussed in a meeting between Rahman and his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi on Wednesday.

## Kerala CM race heats up as AICC observers meet Cong MLAs

Crucial consultations underway on Kerala leadership

OUR CORRESPONDENT

### Vijayan accepts people's mandate against LDF; congratulates UDF

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Breaking his silence after the LDF's heavy defeat in the Kerala Assembly elections, former chief minister and CPI(M) Politburo member Pinarayi Vijayan on Thursday said that he accepted the people's verdict and congratulated the UDF on its victory. "The LDF will move forward with greater clarity and confidence, strengthening its relationship with the people. The fight for the future of Kerala, the welfare of the people, democracy and secularism will continue," Vijayan said.

AGENCIES

The party's state in-charge Deepa Dasmuni, senior state Congress leaders, and newly elected legislators attended the closed-door meeting.

Later, the observers met leaders of the Congress' alliance partners to seek their views on the next Chief Minister.

Senior leader Ramesh Chennithala, former Leader of the Opposition V D Satheesan, and AICC general secretary K C Venugopal are the top contenders for the post. The CLP

meeting was held amid intense lobbying, besides a fierce social media campaign by their camps to garner support for their respective leaders.

Responding to reporters after the CLP meeting, Wasnik said there was an atmosphere of jubilation as the Congress victory in the Assembly election was "remarkable" and "historic".

"It is a matter of great joy, and in this atmosphere the meeting took place," he said.

## India and Vietnam expand tech ties in AI, semiconductors

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI: India and Vietnam on Thursday agreed to expand cooperation across frontier technologies, including artificial intelligence, semiconductors, robotics, biotechnology and cybersecurity, during talks between Union Minister of State for Science and Technology Dr. Jitendra Singh and his Vietnamese counterpart Prof. Dr. Vu Hai Quan in New Delhi.

Held under the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership framework, the discussions focused on strengthening institutional mechanisms for joint research, innovation-led collaboration, and closer engagement between the startup ecosystems of both countries, according to an official readout.

Welcoming the Vietnamese delegation, Dr. Singh described the two nations as civilisational partners with nearly 2,000 years of shared links, and said the partnership had gained fresh momentum following Vietnamese Prime Minister Pham Minh Chinh's visit to India in August 2024. He highlighted Vietnam's importance in India's Act East Policy and Indo-Pacific vision, noting that India-ASEAN cooperation in science and innovation offers a strong platform for future collaboration.

Dr. Singh also proposed deeper linkages between startups, innovators and research institutions of the two countries, pointing to India's growing entrepreneurial ecosystem. Officials said around ten Vietnamese researchers have already

benefited from the India-ASEAN Research and Training Fellowship programme, with several joint projects currently underway.

Prof. Quan expressed Vietnam's interest in structured collaboration on deep technologies with practical applications and suggested appointing dedicated nodal points in both ministries to prepare a concrete action plan. He also confirmed Vietnam would nominate a Deputy Minister-level representative to coordinate future engagement.

Both sides reviewed preparations for the next India-Vietnam Joint Committee Meeting and discussed startup exchanges, co-innovation centres and industry-linked research partnerships.

## 'TN Guv delaying govt formation to help BJP'

NEW DELHI: Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal on Thursday launched a scathing attack on Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar for not inviting Vijay-led TVK to form the government, alleging that governors are "agents" of the BJP who "maul" the Constitution to serve that party's interests.

The former Union minister alleged that Arlekar is trying to "buy time" so that the BJP can manipulate government formation in Tamil Nadu.

Sibal's remarks came amid Vijay's efforts to cobble up support to form his maiden government after his TVK emerged as the single largest party in the April 23 assembly polls. "I was hoping that by now the governor would have invited the TVK to form the government in Tamil Nadu.



TVK's Vijay with Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar

That is the norm, the governor, Mr Arlekar, would be knowing the norm. But of course, when governors become agents of the BJP, they do the bidding of the BJP," Sibal said at a press conference here.

"I am reminded of England off spinner Jim Laker who took 19 wickets in a Test match against Australia in 1956, the highest ever. Arlekar is trying to bowl a spin ball for the gov-

ernment, he is 'their Laker' not Jim Laker," Sibal said, taking a swipe at the governor.

The governor is trying to ensure that somehow the AIADMK and the DMK get together and the TVK is not able to form government, he alleged. "What I hear from media reports is that the DMK has said it will not join hands with any other party to form government," the Independent

Rajya Sabha MP said.

The governor must follow the dictum of the Supreme Court and the recommendations of the Sarkaria Commission, Sibal asserted.

The commission had said that if there is a pre-poll alliance with a majority then the leader of that alliance be called to form the government. If there is no pre-poll alliance, then the leader of the largest party is called to form the government with the support of others and if there is post-poll alliance that has majority then its leader is called to form the government, he pointed out.

"In Tamil Nadu, no single party has a majority. Normally, the single largest party should be asked to form the government. The test of the majority is not domain of the governor, Sibal said.

MP05T

## 'Undemocratic': AIMPLB slams government move on 'Vande Mataram'

NEW DELHI: With the Union Cabinet giving 'Vande Mataram' the same statutory protection as the national anthem 'Jana Gana Mana', the All India Muslim Personal Law Board on Thursday said the move was a direct violation of constitutional rights, including religious freedom, and demanded its withdrawal.

The Union Cabinet has approved a proposal to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 to make any obstruction to the singing of the national song 'Vande Mataram' a punishable offence.

This gives 'Vande Mataram' the same statutory protection as the national anthem 'Jana Gana Mana'. The Act, at present, protects the national anthem, the national flag and the Constitution from any insults.

The All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB) has "strongly" rejected the decision of the Union Cabinet to accord 'Vande Mataram' a status equal to the national anthem 'Jana Gana Mana' to make all six stanzas of the song compulsory, and to mandate its recitation before the national anthem in all government and educational institutions, the Board said in a statement.

The AIMPLB claimed that the move was a "direct violation" of the basic spirit of the Constitution of India, religious freedom, secular values, and the historic decisions of the Constituent Assembly.

It demanded that the government immediately withdraw this decision.

AIMPLB spokesperson S Q R Ilyas said that the Cabinet's decision is not only "unconstitutional and undemocratic", but also contrary to the religious and cultural diversity and constitutional ethos of the country.

MP05T

## Keeping elected govt out hurts anti-terror efforts, says J&K CM

SRINAGAR: Warning against "working in silos", Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has highlighted the disconnect between the security apparatus and the people's representatives and asserted that the region's security challenges cannot be resolved only through a purely military lens.

Speaking about the after effects of last year's Pahalgam massacre of 26 people by terrorists, Abdullah spoke about the complexities of counter terrorism and revival of tourism and argued that keeping the elected government "totally disconnected" from the law-and-order machinery hampers the cross-flow of vital infor-



mation. "The problem is that you're trying to deal with a security situation purely as a security situation. That is never going to be the case. The causes of terror and the effects of terror both have linkages to the wider community. And therefore, when you operate in silos, when the elected government and the elected representatives are kept totally disconnected from the security and the law and order apparatus, then you will end up with this situation," the CM said. In a sharp observation on the disconnect between the law and order machinery and the people's representatives, Abdullah said that the existing gap is so wide that even basic professional courtesies, like a police officer saluting an elected official, have become a source of professional anxiety.

He added that when the police don't even know whether they should be part of a civil function of the elected government, the cross-flow of information also becomes a bit problematic.

MP05T

## Over Rs 1.4K crore seized as Tamil Nadu tops cash, Bengal leads liquor & drug haul

The figures represent a 40.14% increase in seizures as compared to the 2021 polls

NEW DELHI: Inducements worth Rs 1,445 crore were seized during the recent assembly elections in five regions, with Tamil Nadu emerging as the highest contributor in cash seizures and West Bengal recording the largest recoveries of liquor and drugs, the Election Commission said on Thursday.

The seizures were reported from West Bengal, Assam, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and the Union Territory of Puducherry, where polling was held in April and votes were counted on May 4.

According to official data, the total value of seizures represents a 40.14 per cent increase compared to the 2021 assembly elections in the same states and Union Territory, when the total recoveries stood at Rs 1,029.93 crore. The Election Commission attributed the rise to intensified monitoring, improved coordination among enforcement agencies, and enhanced surveillance mechanisms.

West Bengal registered

## Key Points

» According to the data shared by the poll authority, while nearly 155 crore illicit cash was recovered in the four states and Puducherry, liquor worth Rs 183.33 crore (around 70 lakh litres) was also seized

» West Bengal saw the highest increase in the seizures of 68.92 per cent, and Tamil Nadu saw an increase in seizures of 48.40 per cent in 2026 compared to the corresponding figures during the 2021 elections

the highest surge in seizures at 68.92 per cent, while Tamil Nadu recorded an increase of 48.40 per cent compared to the previous elections. Officials noted that both states remained sensitive zones for enforcement activity due to high political competition and reported instances of voter inducement practices.

Of the total recoveries this election cycle, nearly Rs 155 crore was seized in cash alone across the five regions. In addition, liquor worth Rs 183.33

crore—estimated at around 70 lakh litres—was confiscated during enforcement operations aimed at curbing electoral malpractice. The Election Commission also reported large-scale seizures of narcotics and psychotropic substances, with drugs worth nearly Rs 3,338 crore recovered. West Bengal accounted for the highest share of drug seizures at Rs 30.28 crore, while no drug recoveries were reported from Puducherry.

Beyond cash, liquor and



drugs, authorities also flagged the distribution of other inducements used to influence voters. These included items such as sarees, clothes, pressure cookers, utensils and even television sets, which are often distributed by political actors or intermediaries to sway electoral choices.

To ensure free and fair elections, the Commission deployed 376 expenditure observers drawn from the Indian Revenue Service (IRS) and allied accounts services.

## Nation Briefs

### 84% KERALA MLAS FACE CRIMINAL CASES; 69% ARE CROREPATIS: ADR REPORT

NEW DELHI: Kerala has recorded a sharp rise in the number of newly elected MLAs with declared criminal cases and crorepati legislators in its recently concluded elections, a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms and Kerala Election Watch said. The report, which analysed the self-sworn affidavits of 135 out of 140 winning candidates, found that 114 MLAs, or 84 per cent, have declared criminal cases against themselves, up from 96 legislators, or 71 per cent, in the 2021 assembly polls. Among them, 77 winning candidates, or 57 per cent, have declared serious criminal cases, compared to 37 MLAs, or 27 per cent, in 2021. The report said one winning candidate has declared a murder case under IPC Section 302, while another has declared a case related to attempted murder under IPC Section 307.

### RAHUL TO JOIN HARYANA CONGRESS LEADER'S 'SADBHAV YATRA' IN GURUGRAM

CHANDIGARH: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi will join the 'Sadbhav Yatra' of Haryana Congress leader Brijendra Singh in Gurugram district on Friday. Brijendra Singh announced the participation of the former Congress president in a post on X on Thursday. "It is a matter of joy for us that Jananayak @RahulGandhi ji will join the 'Sadbhav Yatra' in Gurugram-Badshahpur tomorrow, thereby strengthening the @INCIndia campaign for brotherhood and harmony.

MP05T



## OUR CORRESPONDENT

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MPOST BUREAU

**NARESH BISWANI**

**MPOST BUREAU**

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## OUR CORRESPONDENT





EDITORIAL

A MANDATE WITHOUT MAJORITY

Electoral verdicts often carry two messages—one of sentiment, the other of structure. In Tamil Nadu, actor-turned-politician Vijay has clearly captured the former. His party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), emerging as the single largest force with 108 seats in a 234-member Assembly, marks one of the most dramatic political entries in recent state history. It signals a decisive shift in voter mood, a willingness to embrace a new political face in a state long dominated by entrenched Dravidian formations. Yet, the second message—the arithmetic of power—remains unresolved. Vijay's tally falls short of the majority mark of 118, and even with potential support from smaller allies, the path to forming a stable government is far from straightforward. In Indian politics, popularity may open doors, but numbers decide who walks through them.

At first glance, the verdict appears emphatic. TVK has outpaced established parties like the DMK and the AIADMK, both of which have shaped Tamil Nadu's political identity for decades. The scale of Vijay's debut inevitably invites comparisons with moments when cinema translated into political capital, most notably with M G Ramachandran and J Jayalalithaa. However, history also cautions against easy parallels. Charisma can win elections, but governance demands a durable legislative base. Once procedural adjustments are factored in—Vijay vacating one of the two seats he has won and the mandatory appointment of a Speaker—the effective strength of the House changes, and so does the majority requirement. Even under favourable calculations, TVK remains dependent on alliances, abstentions or strategic alignments. The Governor's role, guided by constitutional provisions under Articles 163 and 164, becomes critical at this stage, but ultimately, the legitimacy of any claim to power must be tested on the floor of the Assembly.

This is where politics shifts from spectacle to strategy. If Vijay can demonstrate credible support, he may be invited to form the government, subject to a confidence vote. If not, the Governor retains the discretion to call upon the second-largest party—the DMK—to attempt forming a government. In both scenarios, the principle is identical: the ability to command a majority in the House. In fractured mandates, the mechanics of power often hinge on fine margins. The phenomenon of "resort politics," where legislators are sequestered to prevent defections, is not merely theatrical—it reflects the fragility of such outcomes. Absences and abstentions can lower the effective majority threshold, making every vote, and every absence, consequential. For a first-time political leader like Vijay, this phase demands not just public support but organisational discipline and negotiation skills of the highest order.

Beyond the arithmetic lies a more complex political question: what exactly does Vijay's mandate represent? It is tempting to read it as a rejection of the old order and an endorsement of a new, personality-driven politics. There is some merit in that reading. The DMK's reduced tally indicates a degree of voter fatigue, while the AIADMK continues to struggle to regain coherence after the loss of its central leadership. Vijay has stepped into this vacuum, offering a blend of familiarity drawn from cinema and a promise of political renewal. However, a plurality is not a consensus. The electorate has expressed a preference, but not an unambiguous endorsement. This distinction matters. In such situations, governance inevitably becomes an exercise in coalition-building, where ideological flexibility and political pragmatism are essential. The Congress's offer of support reflects this fluidity, but it also underscores the transactional nature of post-poll alliances, where stability depends as much on shared interests as on shared vision.

Ultimately, Vijay's political journey has entered its most demanding phase. The transition from electoral success to effective governance is neither automatic nor assured. Tamil Nadu has historically been shaped by strong, centralised leadership, with clear organisational structures underpinning political authority. Vijay's rise disrupts that pattern, introducing a new formation that must now prove its administrative credibility. The coming days—his meeting with the Governor, the demonstration of support, and the likely floor test—will determine not just who forms the government, but how stable that government will be. A narrow majority, even if secured, can be vulnerable to internal dissent and external pressure. The verdict, therefore, is both an endorsement and a challenge. It marks the arrival of a new political force, but also reaffirms a timeless principle of democracy: that legitimacy rests not only on votes received, but on the ability to command the House. For Vijay, the journey from popular mandate to political authority will depend not on applause, but on arithmetic—and on how effectively he can convert momentum into majority.

SACRED CONTINUUM



NARENDRA MODI

THE WRITER IS THE PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA AND IS ALSO THE CHAIRMAN OF THE SHREE SOMNATH TRUST

More than a temple, Somnath represents a journey—from vidhvans to srijan—where history, faith and national consciousness converge across generations

Somnath and Civilisational Resilience

Across centuries of destruction and rebuilding, Somnath stands as a powerful reminder of India's civilisational resilience, faith and enduring unity

At the start of 2026, I had gone to Somnath for the Somnath Swabhiman Parv, marking a thousand years since the first attack on the Somnath Temple. Now, I will be back in Somnath on May 11 to mark 75 years since the inauguration of the restored Temple by the then President of India, Dr Rajendra Prasad. In less than half a year, it is a privilege to be attending two important milestones relating to Somnath and its journey from ruin to renewal or what we describe as from Vidhvans to Srijan.

Somnath gives us a civilisational message. The vast sea before it evokes timelessness. The waves tell us... that no matter how fierce the storms are or how turbulent the tides are, one can always rise again with dignity and strength. The waves return to the shore, as though reminding every generation that the spirit of the people can never be subdued for long.

Our ancient scriptures say: प्रभासं च परिक्रम्य पुण्यीकृतमसंममम्. It means, a *Pradakshina* of the divine *Prabhasa* (Somnath) is equal to a *Pradakshina* of the whole earth itself! While people have come here to pray, they have also experienced the remarkable continuity of a civilisation whose flame could never be extinguished. Empires rose and fell, tides changed, history moved through conquest and upheaval, yet Somnath continued to endure in our consciousness.

It is time to remember the countless greats who stood firm in the face of tyranny. There were Lakulisha and Soma Sarman, who transformed *Prabhasa* into a great centre of philosophy. Chakravarti Maharaja Dharasena IV of Vallabhi built the Second Temple there centuries ago. Bhima Deva, Jayapala and Anandapala will always be remembered for defending civilisational honour against invasions. It is said that Raja Bhoja too helped with the reconstruction. Karna Deva and Siddharaja Jayasimha played a vital role in restoring Gujarat's political and cultural strength. Bhava Brihas-



Somnath's story is not of the past alone—it is a continuing reminder that India's spirit, rooted in faith and unity, remains unconquered

pati, Kumarapala Solanki and the Pashupata Acharyas rebuilt and sustained the shrine as a great centre of worship and learning. Vishaladeva Vaghela and Tripurantaka protected its intellectual and spiritual traditions. Mahipaladeva and Ra Khangar were instrumental in reviving worship after destruction. Punyashlok Ahilyabai Holkar, whose 300<sup>th</sup> birth centenary is being marked, ensured the continuity of devotion in the most difficult of times. There were the Gaekwads of Baroda, who safeguarded the rights of pilgrims. And of course, our soil is blessed to have nurtured brave personalities like Veer Hamirji Gohil and Veer Veggaji Bhil, whose sacrifice and courage have become a part of Somnath's living memory.

In the 1940s, when the spirit of freedom swept across India and the foundations of a new republic were being laid under the leadership of towering figures like Sardar Patel, one thing continued to trouble him deeply...the condition of Somnath. On November 13, 1947, during Diwali time, he stood

next to the dilapidated ruins of the temple with sea-water in his hands and said, "On this auspicious day of the (Gujarati) New Year, we have decided that Somnath should be reconstructed. You, people of Saurashtra, should do your best. This is a holy task in which all should participate." On one clarion call of Sardar Patel, it was not only the people of Gujarat but also the people of the whole of India that responded enthusiastically.

Unfortunately, fate did not allow Sardar Patel to witness the fulfilment of the dream he had so passionately championed. Before the restored Somnath Temple could open its doors to devotees, he had departed from this world. Yet, his impact continued to be felt over the sacred shores of Prabhas Patan. His vision was championed by Shri KM Munshi, ably supported by the Jamsabeh of Nawanagar. In 1951, when the Temple was complete, it was decided to call the President of India, Dr Rajendra Prasad, for the ceremony. Overcoming strong objections from the then Prime Minister Pandit Nehru, Dr Prasad graced

the ceremony, thus making it even more special and historic.

My mind also goes back to October 2001, when I had just taken over as Chief Minister. On October 31, 2001, the Jayanti of Sardar Patel, the Gujarat Government had the honour of organising a programme to mark 50 years since the Somnath Temple opened its doors. It also coincided with the 125<sup>th</sup> birth anniversary celebrations of Sardar Patel. The then Prime Minister Shri Atal Bihari Vajpayee and the then Home Minister Shri LK Advani attended the programme.

During his speech on May 11, 1951, Dr Rajendra Prasad said that the Somnath Temple proclaims to the world that anything with unparalleled faith and love cannot be destroyed. He expressed hope that this Temple will live in the hearts of people. He also said that the restoration of the Temple was a fulfilment of Sardar Patel's dream, but taking that spirit forward, it is important that we restore prosperity to the lives of people. These are important and inspiring messages he gave.

This is the path we have been walking for over a decade. I consider it my good fortune that, inspired by the principle of '*Vikas Bhi, Virasat Bhi*', from Somnath to Kashi, Kamakhya to Kedarnath, Ayodhya to Ujjain, Trimbakeshwar to Srisaillam, our team has had the opportunity to equip our spiritual centres with the latest facilities while at the same time preserving their traditional character. This, along with efforts to improve connectivity, ensures more people can visit them. It boosts the local economy, secures livelihoods and deepens the spirit of '*Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat*'.

The struggles and sacrifices of those who laid down their lives to protect Somnath and those who rebuilt it time and again will never be forgotten. Countless individuals from different corners of India contributed to restoring its glory. They saw every part of Bharat as sacred, bound together by a sense of oneness that transcended geography. In a world often marked by divisions, this spirit of unity is more relevant than ever. Somnath will continue to stand tall in all its glory because the sense of unity and shared civilisational consciousness lives on in the hearts of every Indian. As a tribute to this, remembering the extraordinary courage of a thousand years, there will be special Pujas at Somnath for the next thousand days. It is gladdening to see several people donating for these Pujas as well.

I urge my fellow Indians to travel to Somnath in this special time. When you stand on the shores of Somnath, let its ancient echoes speak to you. You will not only be overwhelmed by devotion but will also feel the strong pulse of a civilisational spirit that refuses to fade, that is unbroken and unyielding. You will experience Bharat's unconquerable spirit and understand why, despite every effort, our culture remained undefeated and you will have the opportunity to behold the vision of eternal triumph. It will surely be unforgettable.

Jai Somnath!

GREEN THOUGHTS



NEHA TYAGI

THE WRITER IS A QC MICROBIOLOGY SCIENTIST AND RESEARCHER WITH A PHD IN ENVIRONMENTAL ENGINEERING FROM IIT BOMBAY

The crisis is not about breastfeeding. It is about what mothers are forced to consume—untested water shaped by decades of policy, neglect and extraction

Contamination in the First Feed

Uranium contamination in Bihar's breast milk exposes a deeper public health failure, where unsafe groundwater silently enters the most vulnerable bodies

Every breast milk sample tested across six Bihar districts contained uranium. The contamination did not arrive from a factory or a spill. It arrived through the water, through decades of agricultural practice, through the body of a mother who had no idea it was there. The milk is not the problem. The problem is what her country has fed her.

In Khagaria district of Bihar, a young mother nurses her child, drawing water from a borewell she has always trusted. It is clear, odourless, and unremarkable, like millions of such sources across rural India. No official has tested it, and no health worker has warned her. Yet, beneath this appearance of purity lies a risk no mother can see—one that exposes a deeper systemic failure: the absence of routine monitoring, transparent data, and sustained public health vigilance over what remains the most basic determinant of human well-being, safe drinking water.

A study published in *Scientific Reports* in November 2025 documented this for the first time in India. Uranium-238 was found in every one of the 40 breast milk samples collected from mothers across six Bihar districts. Every single one. Concentrations reached up to 5.25 micrograms per litre. The hazard quotient exceeded 1 for 70 per cent of infants, meaning their bodies were receiving more than they can safely process, with nowhere to send what remains. **How Uranium Gets Into The Water**

Uranium sits naturally in India's rocks at 2.8 to 4 parts per million. Two human activities moved it into drinking water: intensive phosphate fertiliser use, which naturally contains uranium at around 100 parts per million, and chronic over-extraction of groundwater, which drops water tables, introduces oxygen and mobilises uranium into aquifers.

The Green Revolution saved hundreds of millions from hunger and left uranium in their grandchildren's drinking water. The fertilisers, tubewells and relentless extraction that made it possible have moved a naturally occurring toxin



The milk is not the problem. The problem is everything that went into the mother before it began

from deep geological formations into the aquifers rural India now depends on. **Problem Far Larger Than Bihar**

Bihar is one data point in a much larger picture. The Central Ground Water Board has identified at least 151 districts across 18 states where groundwater uranium exceeds the WHO's provisional guideline of 30 micrograms per litre. Punjab is now the worst affected state, with over 62 per cent of groundwater samples exceeding safe limits in 2024, up from 24 per cent just five years ago. Haryana, Delhi and Rajasthan follow close behind. Punjab's Malwa region, already associated with elevated cancer rates, has recorded uranium at several hundred micrograms per litre. For families here, the borewell is the only tap. **What Uranium Does Inside A Child**

Uranium sounds like a radiation story. That instinct misses what is actually happening here. At environmental concentrations, uranium behaves like any other heavy metal toxin. It targets the kidney through chemistry, not radioactivity. Finnish population studies found early markers of kidney stress in people

drinking water with uranium at around 28 micrograms per litre over many years. The US Agency for Toxic Substances identifies the kidney as uranium's primary target.

Uranium also accumulates in bone and crosses the blood-brain barrier, with experimental research linking early lactation-period exposure to disrupted neural development and impaired memory in offspring.

For an infant, the vulnerability is sharper. A newborn's kidneys are still forming and have almost no capacity to excrete heavy metals. The Bihar study found infants carried a higher hazard quotient than their own mothers. The damage surfaces years later, in outcomes no one will trace back to a borewell in Khagaria.

None of this is an argument against breastfeeding. A 2024 review reaffirmed it as the WHO-recommended standard even in the presence of contaminants. The Bihar researchers are unambiguous: breastfeeding must continue. The problem is not the milk. The problem is everything that went into the mother before it began.

Shaped By Decades Of Decisions

This contamination is the shadow of India's most celebrated development story. It falls on those with the least say. Wealthier households buy bottled water or install filters. Rural communities on unmonitored borewells cannot test their water and have no alternatives.

India adopted a specific uranium limit for drinking water only in 2021, matching the WHO provisional guideline of 30 micrograms per litre. Germany set its uranium drinking water limit at 10 micrograms per litre, three times stricter, because "provisional", when a child's kidney is the target, is not sufficient. India has adopted the floor, not the ceiling. And even that floor is not being routinely monitored in the 151 districts where it matters most.

Trusting The Water

This study has traced a line from the geology of the Indo-Gangetic plain, through decades of agricultural practice, through a mother's body, into her milk. That line runs through Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan and every household where the only tap is a borewell.

The mother in Khagaria is trusting the water. She is trusting the country whose systems are supposed to make that trust safe. The discomfort of this finding belongs not to her. It belongs to everyone who has the information, the authority and the means to act, and has not yet decided that these communities are worth the urgency.

The path forward is not complicated. India must expand routine uranium testing to all 151 identified districts and make results accessible to the communities that depend on that water. It must integrate environmental exposure screening into maternal and child health programmes in affected states. And it must revisit the 2021 BIS uranium limit, a standard written for general populations, not for infants whose kidneys are still forming. The science demands a stricter threshold. The communities bearing this burden have been waiting long enough.

Views expressed are personal



‘MOSCOW SHOT DOWN 347 UKRAINIAN DRONES OVERNIGHT’

# Ukraine launched major attack after Moscow shunned truce offer: Russia

KYIV: Russian air defences shot down 347 Ukrainian drones overnight, Russia's Defence Ministry said Thursday, in what appeared to be a major attack after Moscow spurned Kyiv's ceasefire earlier in the week and tension mounted over safety at Russia's upcoming Victory Day celebrations.

Incoming drones were destroyed over 20 Russian regions, including Moscow, according to the Defence Ministry, in Ukraine's second-biggest aerial attack since Russia's all-out invasion more than four years ago. The largest was last March when it launched 389 drones.

Dozens more Ukrainian drones were launched during daylight hours Thursday, the ministry said, including some heading again toward Moscow.

Nearly 100 flights in and out of the Russian capital's three main airports — Sheremetyevo, Domodedovo



Smoke rises from a car service workshop destroyed by a Russian strike on Zaporizhzhia

and Vnukovo — were delayed or cancelled by midday, the Moskva news agency reported. The attacks came ahead of Russia's most important secular holiday, Victory Day, which marks the anniversary of the defeat of Nazi Germany in World War II. Russian authorities have declared a unilateral ceasefire in Ukraine for Friday and Saturday.

### Highlights

- » Incoming drones were destroyed over 20 Russian regions
- » It is Ukraine's second-biggest aerial attack since Russia's all-out invasion more than four years ago
- » The attacks came ahead of Russia's most important secular holiday, Victory Day

Ukraine had responded to that with its own suspension of hostilities from midnight Tuesday. But Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Moscow disregarded the goodwill gesture and launched fresh attacks. "Russia has not stopped any type of its military activity. Unfortunately, it has not stopped. Ukraine will act symmetrically," Zelenskyy said in his regular evening video address Wednesday.

He said Thursday on X that Russia's attacks have been ceaseless, with drones, missiles, artillery shelling and glide bombs hitting civilian areas of Ukraine, including the power grid and rail network.

In the northeastern city of Kharkiv, Ukraine's second-largest, a drone strike wounded nine people, including three children, local officials said.

Tension has grown as Russia's Victory Day celebrations approach and US-led peace efforts gain no traction. AGENCIES

## Hantavirus: Dozens of passengers left cruise ship after first death

THE HAGUE: More than two dozen passengers from at least 12 different countries left a cruise ship hit by a deadly hantavirus outbreak on April 24 without contact tracing, nearly two weeks after the first passenger died on board, the ship operator and Dutch officials said Thursday.

The news raised concerns that the virus could spread as travellers returned home, although experts say the risk to the wider public is considered low as hantavirus isn't easily transmitted between people.

Even so, the Dutch health ministry said a woman who was not on the ship was being tested for hantavirus and being kept in an isolated ward in an Amsterdam hospital after showing symptoms. The woman was part of a flight crew and had contact with an infected passenger on the plane, it said.

If the woman tests positive, she could be the first known person not on the MV Hondius to become infected in the outbreak. Health authorities were monitoring people or trying to trace others who may have come into contact with



Medics escort a patient (second left), evacuated from the MV Hondius cruise ship with suspected hantavirus infection, to an ambulance after being flown to Schiphol airport in Amsterdam

“THE NEWS RAISED CONCERNS THAT THE VIRUS COULD SPREAD AS TRAVELLERS RETURNED HOME”

Three people, including the ship's doctor, were evacuated Wednesday while the ship was near the West African island country of Cape Verde and taken to specialised hospitals in Europe for treatment.

The Netherlands-based cruise ship company had previously said the body of the Dutch man who was the first to die on board on April 11 was taken off the ship on the remote South Atlantic island of St. Helena on April 24, when his wife also disembarked. AGENCIES

cruise passengers on at least four continents.

Three cruise ship passengers have died in the outbreak, and several others are sick.

## Rubio makes fence-mending visit to Vatican after Trump's clash with Pope

VATICAN CITY: The Vatican raised the "need to work tirelessly in favour of peace" in talks Thursday with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who came to Rome on a fence-mending visit after President Donald Trump's criticisms of Pope Leo XIV over the Iran war.

Both the Vatican and the US State Department stressed that Rubio's meetings with Leo and the Vatican's top diplomat underscored strong bilateral ties.

Those relations, though, have been strained over Trump's repeated broadsides about Leo's calls for peace and dialogue to end the US-Israeli war.

Rubio, a practicing Catholic, has often been called on to tone down or explain Trump's harsh rhetoric. He had an audience first with Leo, which was complicated at the last minute by Trump's latest criticism of the Chicago-born pope. During a 2½-hour visit, Rubio then met with the Vatican secretary of state, Cardinal Pietro Parolin, who on the eve of his visit had strongly defended Leo and criticised Trump's attacks.

"Attacking him like that or criticising what he does seems a bit strange to me, to say the least," Parolin said Wednesday.

After the meetings, the US State Department said that Rubio



Pope Leo XIV with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio

Both the Vatican and the US State Department stressed that Rubio's meetings with Leo and the Vatican's top diplomat underscored strong bilateral ties

and Parolin discussed "ongoing humanitarian efforts in the Western Hemisphere and efforts to achieve a durable peace in the Middle East. The discussion reflected the enduring partnership between the United States and the

Holy See in advancing religious freedom."

In a separate statement about the audience with Leo, US State Department spokesperson Tommy Pigott said that the two discussed the situation in the Middle East and the Western Hemisphere. "The meeting underscored the strong relationship between the United States and the Holy See and their shared commitment to promoting peace and human dignity," he said.

The Vatican, for its part, said that during Rubio's meetings with both Leo and Parolin, "the shared commitment to fostering good bilateral relations between the Holy See and the United States of America was reaffirmed." AGENCIES

## Man with weapon arrested near ex-Prince Andrew's home

LONDON: A man has been arrested on suspicion of possessing an offensive weapon after reports that the former Prince Andrew was threatened by a masked man while walking dogs near his home.

Norfolk Constabulary said that the arrest came Wednesday evening after a man was reported "behaving in an intimidating manner" near the home of Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor in eastern England.

"Officers attended, and the man was arrested on suspicion of a public order offense and possession of an offensive weapon," the force

### Key Points

- » The suspect is being held for questioning at a nearby police station
- » A newspaper reported that a man wearing a ski mask ran toward former royal while abusing

ANDREW NOW LIVES AT MARSH FARM, A PROPERTY ON THE SANDRINGHAM ESTATE, AFTER LEAVING ROYAL LODGE LAST YEAR

said.

The suspect is being held for questioning at a nearby police station.

The term offensive weapons covers knives, truncheons and other items used to cause injury. Police didn't specify

what type of weapon was involved.

The Daily Telegraph newspaper reported that a man wearing a ski mask ran toward the former royal while shouting abuse.

It said the incident

## Israel indicts Jewish man accused of attacking Christian nun in Jerusalem

TEL AVIV: Israel on Thursday indicted a Jewish man over a violent attack on a nun near Jerusalem's Old City last week, the latest in a string of high-profile incidents targeting Christians and religious symbols.

The indictment identified the man as Yona Schreiber, 36, from the

Israeli-occupied West Bank settlement of Peduel. It comes after a video of the assault received wide condemnation from foreign and Christian leaders.

Schreiber was arrested last week, and Israel's attorney general recommended extending his detention for the duration

of the case. Schreiber's lawyer refused to speak to an Associated Press journalist at the court.

According to the indictment, Schreiber attacked a woman in Jerusalem, just outside of the walls of Jerusalem's Old City, because she was wearing a habit that identified her as a Catholic nun. AGENCIES

## China signals that Taiwan to be priority ahead of Trump-Xi meeting

BEIJING: China again signaled that Taiwan would be a priority topic ahead of a highly anticipated summit between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping next week, saying that the US must adhere to the "one China principle" for a stable relationship with Beijing.

Last week, China's top diplomat Wang Yi said he hopes the US would make the "right choices" relating to the self-ruled island when he spoke with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

China claims Taiwan as its own territory and has not excluded the use of force to take it. Beijing has been ramping up its military pressure by sending warplanes and naval vessels around the island almost daily.

"The Taiwan question is at the core of China's core interests and the bedrock of the political foundation of China-U.S. relations," said Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian Thursday.

"Abiding by the One China principle and the three China-US joint communiqués and honouring the commitments made by US administrations on the Taiwan question, is the due international obligation of the United States and the prerequisite for a steady, sound, and sustainable China-US relationship," he added.

Such strong language so close in time to the two leaders' meeting is rare for Beijing, said Arthur Zhin-Sheng Wang, a defense expert at Taiwan's Central Police University. AGENCIES

## British PM Starmer's leadership to be stress tested by local polls

LONDON: British Prime Minister Keir Starmer's leadership is on the line as millions turn out to vote in key local and devolved parliamentary elections across the UK on Thursday.

The biggest polls since the UK general election in 2024 are being pitched as a stress test of Starmer's hold as leader of the Labour Party, the governing party that is lagging behind smaller parties in pre-poll surveys.

Ahead of the poll outcome, the stage is being set for a potential challenge by some sections of the party to try and notch up the 81 Labour MPs needed to launch an all-out rebellion in favour of electing a new party leader.

However, Starmer is expected to come out fighting on Friday as the results begin pouring in to fight back against any moves to replace him.

In England, more than 4,500 councillors are set to be elected across 136 councils as well as some local borough mayors. In Scotland and Wales, voters will elect members of the Scottish Parliament and Welsh Senedd respectively.

Niki Nixon of the UK's Electoral Commission reminded voters to carry identification to be able to vote at the polling booths, which will remain open until 10 pm local time on Thursday. "You'll need to show it to polling station staff before they give you your ballot paper. Don't risk being turned away, check you have ID with you



UK PM Keir Starmer

The biggest polls since the UK general election in 2024 are being pitched as a stress test of Starmer's hold as leader of the Labour Party

before heading to the polling station," said Nixon.

According to pollsters, both the governing Labour and Opposition Conservatives are unlikely to fare well as voters tend to use local elections to register their discontent with the central administration at Westminster.

The far-right anti-immigration Reform UK, led by Nigel Farage, and far-left Green Party led by Zack Polanski are hoping to make strong gains in the councils across the country. The Liberal Democrats, led by Ed Davey, are also hoping to pick up votes from discontented Labour and Tory voters from an electorate base of an estimated 30 million people. AGENCIES

THERE ARE NEARLY 410 CLIMBERS AT BASE CAMP

## Mt. Everest season opens despite huge unstable ice block & high travel costs

KATHMANDU: An unstable ice block dangerously hanging over the key trail on Mount Everest, high travel costs and increased permit fees haven't deterred hundreds of climbers from attempting to scale the world's highest mountain.

Around 410 climbers and an equal number of their Nepali climbing guides are at the base camp gearing up for the ascent to the nearly 8,850-meter-high (around 29,000-foot-high) peak this month during the much anticipated window of good weather on the mountain.

Climbers began gathering last month at the base camp, which is at an altitude of 5,300 meters (17,340 feet). But for more than two weeks, a massive and unstable block of ice, or serac, stalled them from moving further up the peak.

"Icefall doctors," the elite guides deployed by the Sagarmatha Pollution Control Committee, or SPCC, to lay the yearly climbing route by setting ropes and securing aluminum ladders over crevasses, usually finish the task by mid-April.

But not this year. The team opened the Icefall route only on April 29 but also issued a warning: "The serac has multiple cracks and may collapse at any time. SPCC strongly urges all expedition operators and climbers to exercise extreme caution."

The serac was likely to remain, and the new trail dug by the team passes below the serac.

The serac is part of the



A mountaineer walks at Khumbu Icefall before beginning his ascent to the summit of Mount Everest

### Takeaways

- » Climbers began gathering last month at the base camp, which is at an altitude of 5,300 meters.
- » The team opened the Icefall route only on April 29 but also issued a warning
- » It's considered one of the most difficult and trickiest sections of the climb to the peak

Khumbu Icefall, a constantly shifting glacier with deep crevasses and huge overhanging ice that can be as big as 10-story buildings. It's considered one of

the most difficult and trickiest sections of the climb to the peak.

Climbers, their guides and expedition outfitters are both eager and cautious about the situation on the mountain.

Renowned mountain guide Lukas Furtenbach, who has 40 international climbers, 11 guides and 90 Sherpas on Mount Everest, said that he was worried.

"Anyone who says they're not concerned is either inexperienced or not paying attention," Furtenbach said from the base camp. "The serac is a real, objective hazard."

He said that the route was more complex and exposed than last year in one section.

"The Icefall is constantly changing, but right now it's not

just more broken — it's also forced into a line that passes under unstable features," he said.

This year, the team is reducing loads, minimizing exposure time, carefully timing movements through the Icefall, and relying on highly experienced Sherpa and guides for risk assessment.

Other expedition operators are also cautioning their members about the risks and closely monitoring the situation.

"If you go in the morning, it might be safer because the ice is frozen, but in the afternoon it becomes dangerous as weather gets warmer, with the risk of ice melting and falling," said Ang Tshering Sherpa of the Kathmandu-based Asian Trekking. AGENCIES

## World Briefs

### NORWEGIAN POLICE ARREST CHINESE CITIZEN ON SPYING ALLEGATIONS

OSLO: Authorities in Norway arrested a Chinese citizen on espionage allegations Thursday in connection with a purported effort to set up a receiver to collect sensitive satellite data, the country's domestic intelligence service said. Norwegian security officials also searched two premises in connection with the arrest, including one on an island in northern Norway that's home to Andoya Spaceport, which is part of Europe's efforts to expand its presence in space. The other search took place in Innlandet, in southern Norway. Police launched their operation on the suspicion that a Norwegian-registered company was operating as a front for a Chinese state actor, the Police said.

### B'DESH MEASLES TOLL REACHES 336 AS 12 MORE CHILDREN DIE OVERNIGHT

DHAKA: Twelve children have died of measles in Bangladesh in the past 24 hours, as the death toll of the contagious disease's outbreak reached 336, authorities said on Thursday. The toll continues to rise despite a massive remedial campaign launched to halt the disease's rapid spread. "In the past 24 hours, 1,238 children with measles symptoms were admitted to hospitals nationwide and during the same time, 12 children died," said DGHS. He said since the outbreak began on Mar 15, at least 336 children lost their lives from confirmed measles infections or symptoms of the disease.



# Iran reviews US proposal to end war

*This comes after Trump threatened Tehran with a new wave of bombing unless a deal is reached*

DUBAI: Iran said it was reviewing the latest American proposals to end the war after US President Donald Trump threatened the country with a new wave of bombing unless a deal is reached that includes reopening the crucial Strait of Hormuz to international shipping. Hope that the two-month conflict could soon be over buoyed international markets Thursday, a day after the US military fired on an Iranian oil tanker attempting to breach the American

blockade of Iran's ports. The developments followed days of mixed messages from the Trump administration over its strategy to end the war. Meanwhile, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio discussed peace efforts in the Middle East at the Vatican. Rubio met with Pope Leo XIV, whose opposition to the Iran war has led to open sparring with Trump. Trump posted on social media Wednesday that ending the war and resuming oil and natural gas shipments dis-



Representational Image

rupted by the conflict depends on Iran accepting an agreement, which he did not detail. "If they don't agree, the

The developments followed days of mixed messages from the Trump administration over its strategy to end the war

bombing starts," Trump wrote. A fragile ceasefire between the US and Iran has largely held since April 8. But in-

person talks between the two countries hosted by Pakistan last month failed to reach an agreement. The war began February 28, when the US and Israel launched strikes against Iran. "We expect an agreement sooner rather than later," Pakistani Foreign Ministry spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said Thursday. "We hope the parties will reach a peaceful and sustainable solution that will contribute not only to peace in our region but to international peace as well." But he declined to give a

timeline, saying Pakistan would not disclose details of the ongoing diplomatic efforts. Asked whether Pakistan was expecting any response from Iran later Thursday, Andrabi said: "I will not comment on specifics or the movement of the messages." Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, speaking in televised remarks, said Islamabad remained in "continuous contact with Iran and the United States, day and night, to stop the war and extend the ceasefire." AGENCIES

## Flights carrying women, children linked to IS group land in Australia

MELBOURNE: Airliners carrying Australian women and children with alleged ties to the Islamic State group landed in Australia on Thursday.

A plane reportedly carrying three Australian women and eight children landed in Melbourne, while a separate plane carrying a woman and her son arrived in Sydney soon after.

The Australian government announced on Wednesday that the 13, who have spent years in a Syrian desert camp, planned to return to Australia. Police said the women face potential criminal charges relating to their alleged time in the Islamic State group's so-called caliphate that spanned Syria and Iraq. Both Qatar Airways flights took off minutes apart

from Doha bound for Australia's two largest cities. QR904, which landed in Melbourne first, was followed by QR908 in Sydney. The Australian government had condemned the women for supporting Islamic State militants by traveling to Syria and had refused to help repatriate them.

Police have been investigating for more than a decade Australians' potential involvement in atrocities while in Syria, including terrorism offenses and crimes against humanity such as slave trading.

Deakin University extremism expert Joshua Roose said Australian authorities were investigating abuses within the caliphate including enslaving Yazidi women and harsh policing of sharia law. AGENCIES

**PUBLIC NOTICE**  
I, Yashoda Chauhan, W/o Satish Kumar, R/o House No. 13A, Nangla Gujran, Village Nekpur, Fatehpur Taga Road, Shop 8, Near Shri Ram School, NIT Faridabad-121004, have disowned my son Vishnu Kumar Chauhan and daughter-in-law Dolly, who are beyond my control, and have broken all ties with them due to their quarrels and threats of implicating me in false cases. In future, if they engage in any transaction or illegal activity with anyone, they will be responsible for it themselves. I and my family will not be responsible for it.

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I, **Swayam Gupta**, S/o Shri Moolchand Gupta, R/o 18/297 Dakshinpur Ambedkar nagar New delhi 110062 do hereby declare That in my Class 10th Marksheet/ Certificate issued by C B S E Board year 2021, bearing Roll No. 14134628, my name has been wrongly/ incorrectly mentioned as **Swayam Gupta** That the names **Swayam Gupta** and **Swayam Gupta** one and the same person

**कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय**  
**राष्ट्रीय ग्रामीण नियोजन कार्यक्रम, रॉची**

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| क्रम सं० | योजना का नाम                                                                       | प्राकृतित राशि/ प्रशासनिक स्वीकृति की राशि | अग्रघन की राशि | परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य | कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि | रॉच सयंत्र का स्वाभिव |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------------|------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------|
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Start Date 12.05.2026 to 11.00 AM  
End Date 19/05/2026 up to : 2.00 PM

6. Date of Publication of Tender on Website Start Date 12.05.2026 Time : 11.00 AM  
End Date 19/05/2026 Time : 11.00 AM

5. Bids online Submission Date 20/05/2025 Time : 11.00 AM

6. Technical Bid Opening Date

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|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------|------------------------|
| CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/AL/1358 | "Scheme No: JF25ML1165 - SHIFTING OF 11KV LINE BY CONVERSION OF OH INTO UG CABLE LINE PASSING THROUGH MITRAON VILLAGE AREA IN" | 1.25 Crore         | 2.50 Lakhs      | 28.05.2026 15:30 HRS          | 28.05.2026 15:45 HRS   |

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Regd. Off.: BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527  
Telephone No.: +91 11 4910 7235 | Website: [www.bsesdelhi.com](http://www.bsesdelhi.com)

**कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, लघु सिंचाई प्रमंडल, रॉची**  
**कमरा नं० 302, तृतीय तल्ला, अभियंत्रण भवन, कचहरी चौक, रॉची- 834001**  
**ई-मेल - eemidran-cemr-jhr@nic.in, midranchi2018@gmail.com**  
**फोन नं० - 0651-3512781**

पत्रांक...../ रॉची, दिनांक ...../...../2026

**शुद्धि-पत्र**

कार्यपालक अभियंता, लघु सिंचाई प्रमंडल, रॉची का पत्रांक- 395 दिनांक-04.05.2026 द्वारा e-Tender Reference No. WRD/MID/04/BD/(SLI) 2026-27, PR 379050 Minor Irrigation (26-27):D दिनांक 06.05.2026 को प्रकाशित निविदा में निम्न प्रकार संशोधन किया जाता है:-

| क्रमांक | विवरण                                                            | पूर्व में अंकित निविदा का तिथि, समय एवं मोबाईल नं० | संशोधित निविदा का तिथि, समय एवं मोबाईल नं० |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| 1       | Technical Bid Opening Date & Time                                | Date: 22.05.2026 Time 2:00 PM                      | Date: 22.05.2026 Time 5:00 PM              |
| 2       | Contact No. of Procurement Officer e-mail of Procurement Officer | 9431190681                                         | 9801286765                                 |

निविदा की शेष सभी शर्तें पूर्वतः बनी रहेंगी।  
**PR 379223 Minor Irrigation(26-27):D**

विश्वासमानजन कार्यपालक अभियंता, लघु सिंचाई प्रमंडल, रॉची

**कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय**  
**लघु सिंचाई रूपांकण प्रमण्डल, दुमका शिविर देवघर**

**शुद्धि-पत्र**

इस कार्यलय द्वारा आमंत्रित निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या- WRD/M.I.D.D.D.C/DEOGHAR/B.D./S.L.I-02/2026-27, Dated :- 24/04/26 - जिसका Pr.No. 378368 Water Resource (26-27) D, द्वारा दिनांक 25.04.2026 को विभिन्न सामाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित किया गया है। उक्त निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना में निम्न परिवर्तन किया जाता है:-

| e-Pro Notice क्रमांक                                                                                                        | पूर्व में                                                               | संशोधित तिथि                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7. Date of Publication of Tender on website ( <a href="http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in">http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in</a> ) | Date: 29.04.2026, 11:00 A.M.                                            | Date: 08.05.2026, 11:00 A.M.                                            |
| 8. Last Date/ Time for downloading of bidding documents and submission of Tender on Website                                 | Date: 14.05.2026, 05:00 P.M.                                            | Date: 21.05.2026, 05:00 P.M.                                            |
| 9. Submission of Tender Fee and EMD                                                                                         | Start Date: 29.04.2026, 11:00 A.M.<br>Last Date: 14.05.2026, 05:00 P.M. | Start Date: 08.05.2026, 11:00 A.M.<br>Last Date: 21.05.2026, 05:00 P.M. |
| 10. Technical Bid Opening Date                                                                                              | Date: 15.05.2026, 05:00 P.M.                                            | Date: 22.05.2026, 05:00 P.M.                                            |

शेष सभी सूचनाएं पूर्ववत् रहेंगी।  
**PR 379214 Water Resource(26-27):D** लघु सिंचाई रूपांकण प्रमण्डल, दुमका शिविर देवघर

**New Okhla Industrial Development Authority**  
Main Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.)  
Website: [www.noidaauthorityonline.in](http://www.noidaauthorityonline.in)

**E-TENDER NOTICE**

E-Tenders are invited from eligible contractors/firm for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: [www.noidaauthorityonline.in](http://www.noidaauthorityonline.in) & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

**A) Fresh-Tender Work:**

| S. No. | Jobs No.                  | Name of the work                                                                   | Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs) |
|--------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 1      | 30/GM/SM(WC-5)/ 2026-2027 | M/o Building (Construction of Pink Toilet in Community Center in Sector-34), Noida | 9.74                     |

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 08.05.2026 to 25.05.2026 up to 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated 26.05.2026 at 11.00 AM.

**B) Re-Tender Work:**

| S. No. | Jobs No.                    | Name of the work                                                                                                                    | Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs) |
|--------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 2      | 39/DGM/SM(WC-2)/ ET/2025-26 | M/o Road (P/F Retro Reflective overhead Signage Board in A, B, C-Block, Sector-31), Noida.                                          | 22.99                    |
| 3      | 20/DGM/SM(WC-5)/ 2025-26    | M/o Boundary wall (Repair of Boundary wall, Grit wash plaster and P/F Coil Fencing of Commercial Plot in C-Block Sector-71), Noida. | 15.27                    |
| 4      | 77/GM/SM (WC-5) / 2025-26   | D/o Village (Repair, Boundary wall and Renovation in Community Centre in Village-Gijhore), Noida.                                   | 25.74                    |

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 08.05.2026 to 14.05.2026 up to 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated 15.05.2026 at 11.00 AM.

**General Manager (Civil) NOIDA**

**CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA**

**SPECIAL BRNACH**  
**POICE HEADQUARTER, M.P., BHOPAL**

NO. SB / Store/2026-25 ( 326 ), Bhopal, Dated 29 -04-2026

**"ONLINE E-TENDER NOTICE "**

E-tender are invited by Assistant Inspector General of Police, Special Branch (G) M.P., Bhopal on behalf of DGP MP Bhopal for the following item on website <https://mptenders.gov.in/nicgp/app/>:-

| S.No. | Name of Item(s)              | Qty. | Tender Fees (Rs.)                                                           | EMD (Rs.)  | Tender No.             |
|-------|------------------------------|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|------------------------|
|       |                              |      | Paid Online Through <a href="https://mptenders.gov.in">mptenders.gov.in</a> |            |                        |
| 1     | Audio Investigation Software | 01   | 10,000/-                                                                    | 3,96,000/- | 1 <sup>st</sup> Tender |

1. Cost of tender document (Tender Fee) is non refundable and cannot be exempted in any condition & must submit online through website <https://mptenders.gov.in/nicgp/app/>.  
2. Tender document can be download from the website of MP Police ([www.mppolice.gov.in](http://www.mppolice.gov.in))  
3. Bids shall be submitted online only at MP Tenders website: <https://mptenders.gov.in/nicgp/app/>

**4. Tender Schedule :**

| No.  | Tender Activity                                                                                                    | Date & Time                            |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| i    | E-Tender Publish Date                                                                                              | 30/04/2026 at 1400 hrs.                |
| ii   | Tender document download Start Date                                                                                | 30/04/2026 up to 1430 hrs.             |
| iii  | Submission of written queries - through e-mail: <a href="mailto:aigg-sb@mpolice.gov.in">aigg-sb@mpolice.gov.in</a> | 05/05/2026 up to 1700 hrs.             |
| iv   | Pre Bid Meeting along with written queries                                                                         | 06/05/2026 at 1200 hrs.                |
| v    | Bid Submission Start Date                                                                                          | 11/05/2026 at 1000 hrs.                |
| vi   | Last date of online e-Tender submission                                                                            | 20/05/2026 up to 1600 hrs.             |
| vii  | Bid will be opened on                                                                                              | 21/05/2026 up to 1600 hrs.             |
| viii | Demonstration from                                                                                                 | Demo date will be announced separately |

5. Intending Bidders are advised to visit this website regularly till closing date or submission to keep themselves updated as any change/ modification in the tender will be intimated through this website only by corrigendum /addendum/ amendment.  
6. Bids will be opened as per date/time as mentioned in the Tender Critical Date Sheet. After online opening of Technical-Bid the results of their qualification as well Price-Bid opening will be intimated later.

sd/- DPG of Police  
(Intelligence(G) M.P. Bhopal  
Tel No. 0755-2443654

G12521/26 "स्वभाव स्वच्छता, संस्कार स्वच्छता"

**BANK OF INDIA**  
**NEW DELHI ASSET RECOVERY BRANCH**  
**3rd Floor, Star House, Behind PVR Plaza, Connaught Circus, New Delhi- 110001**  
**Phone : 01123755605 E-mail : [AssetRecovery.NewDelhi@bankofindia.bank.in](mailto:AssetRecovery.NewDelhi@bankofindia.bank.in)**

**E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002**

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged/charged to the Bank of India (Secured Creditor), the possession of which have been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Bank of India, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on **26.05.2026 from 11.00 A.M. to 5.00 P.M.** through E-Auction under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

| Sr. No. | Borrower(s) /Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) Name                                                                                                                                                 | Description of the immovable Properties                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Total Dues                                                   | a. Reserve Price<br>b. EMD<br>c. Incremental Bid           | Authorised Officer with Contact No.           |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 1.      | <b>Owner of the Property :</b> Mrs. Seema Chaudhary<br><b>Borrower :</b> Mrs. Seema Chaudhary                                                                                                | Entire First Floor (without roof rights/terrace rights) of built up free hold property number BE-40 D built upon land admeasuring 67 sq. yards, part of Khasra No. 2007 & 2008 situated in the area of village Tihar, Now colony known as BE Block, Hari Nagar, Clock Tower, New Delhi-110064 with 1/4 <sup>th</sup> undivided share of land rights out of total land. | Rs. 36,30,871 + unchanged interest                           | a) Rs. 49,50,000/-<br>b) Rs. 4,95,000/-<br>c) Rs. 50,000/- | Akhilesh Kumar<br>Chief Manager<br>9873896078 |
| 2.      | <b>Owner of the Property :</b> Mr Jitender Aggarwal & Mr. Ajay Aggarwal<br><b>Borrower :</b> M/s Alok Enterprises<br><b>Partners :</b> 1. Mr. Jitender Agarwal<br>2. Mr. Ajay Kumar Aggarwal | All that part and parcel of the property consisting of Shop/Unit bearing Pvt. No. 201 on 2 <sup>nd</sup> Floor, constructed on plot no. VI/3222, Situated at Prem Market, Gali Charan Dass, Charkewalan, Chawri Bazar, Delhi-1100006 (area 11.15 sq. Mt)                                                                                                               | For Bank of India - Rs.38.97 Lacs plus UCI and other Charges | a) Rs. 11,55,000/-<br>b) Rs. 1,15,000/-<br>c) Rs. 25,000/- | Akhilesh Kumar<br>Chief Manager<br>9873896078 |

**TERMS AND CONDITIONS**

1) Auction sale /bidding would be only through "Online Electronic Bidding" process through the website <https://baanknet.com>.  
2) The intending bidders should register at portal <https://baanknet.com> and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer/Generation of challan form (<https://baanknet.com>).  
3) Date and time of Auction: 26.05.2026 from 11:00 AM to 05:00 PM with unlimited Auto-Extensions of 05 Minutes Each.  
4) Property can be inspected on Between 25.05.2026 with prior Appointment from respective Authorised Officer.  
5) E-Auction would commence on the Reserve Price plus first incremental value as mentioned above. Bidders shall improve their offers in multiples mentioned in the above table for all the properties simultaneously.  
6) The intending bidders should deposit EMD i.e. 10% of Reserve Price online in the BAANKNET EMD Wallet along with the required documents / details well before 26.05.2026 on the <https://baanknet.com> for smooth participation in e-auction.  
7) The highest / successful bidder shall deposit 25% of the amount of /purchase money (including EMD already paid i.e. 10% of bid amount) immediately but not later than the next working day (during banking hours) of confirmation of the sale by the Authorized Officer after acceptance of bid by the Authorized Officer in respect of the sale, failing which the EMD shall be forfeited.  
8) The balance 75% of the bid/purchase money shall be payable on or before 15th day (during banking hours) of confirmation of the sale by the Authorized Officer or such extended period as agreed upon in writing by and solely at the discretion of the Authorized Officer. In case of failure to deposit this balance amount within the prescribed period, the amount deposited shall be forfeited and the Authorized Officer / Bank will be at liberty to cancel the auction and conduct fresh auction.  
9) On receipt of the entire sale consideration, the Authorized Officer shall issue the Sale Certificate and the sale shall be considered complete thereafter and that the Bank shall entertain no claims.  
10) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link - <https://www.bankofindia.co.in/DynamicTender?Type=3>  
11) Needless to state that property listed for E-auction is being sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" there by all the dues related to the property will be borne by the auction purchaser, (if any)  
12) This publication is also 15 days' notice to the above borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors to the advance.  
13) In case of discrepancy between English version and any other vernacular version of this notice, the English version shall prevail.

Date : 08-05-2026 Place : New Delhi Authorised Officer, Bank of India



UNABATED FOREIGN FUND OUTFLOWS

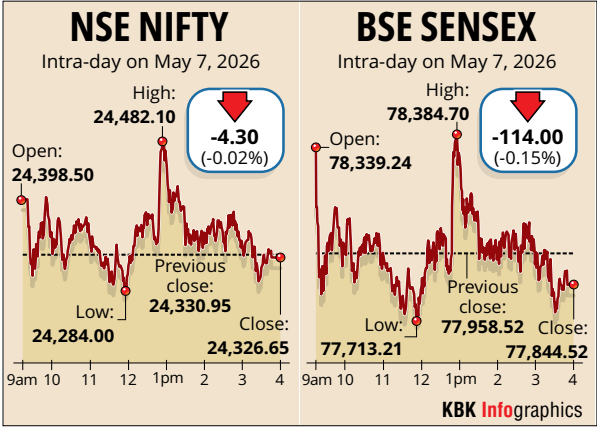
# Stock markets end lower in choppy trade; Sensex declines 114 points

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**MUMBAI:** Benchmark indices ended lower in a choppy trade on Thursday, with the Sensex declining 114 points, as investors turned cautious amid unabated foreign fund outflows and rising geopolitical uncertainties.

After facing heavy fluctuations during the day, the 30-share BSE Sensex ended 114 points or 0.15 per cent lower at 77,844.52. During the session, the benchmark hit a high of 78,384.70 and a low of 77,713.21, gyrating 671.49 points. The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 4.30 points, or 0.02 per cent, to end at 24,326.65.

From the Sensex firms, Hindustan Unilever, Tata Consultancy Services, Tech Mahindra, Titan, Sun Pharma and ITC were among the major laggards. On the other hand, Mahindra & Mahindra, NTPC, Kotak Mahindra Bank and Tata



Steel were among the winners. The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 1.40 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index climbed 1.09 per cent.

Sectorally, Focused IT fell 0.76 per cent, PSU Bank (0.54 per cent), Consumer Durables (0.52 per cent), FMCG (0.45 per cent), Energy (0.11 per cent), Capital Goods jumped 2.05 per cent, Power (1.23 per

cent), Auto (1.81 per cent), Industrials (1.69 per cent), Power (1.23 per cent) and Realty (0.88 per cent).

“The positive undertone was primarily driven by a sharp cooling in crude oil prices amid optimism surrounding a potential US–Iran peace agreement. Stability in the rupee, improving global sentiment, and continued buying interest in select

HIGHLIGHTS

» Nifty dipped 4.30 points, or 0.02 per cent, to end at 24,326.65

» From the Sensex firms, Hindustan Unilever, TCS, Tech Mahindra, Titan, Sun Pharma & ITC were among major laggards

» Mahindra & Mahindra, NTPC, Kotak Mahindra Bank and Tata Steel were among the winners

The rupee pared initial losses to settle on a positive note, 23 paise higher at 94.26 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 5,834.90 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index were trading higher. Markets in Europe were trading lower.

US markets ended sharply higher on Wednesday.

“The Indian stock market closed on a slightly cautious note today. Continued FII outflows and subdued global cues weighed on the market. Ongoing geopolitical uncertainties also kept investor confidence in check, impacting overall risk appetite,” Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

## Air India board meets in Delhi

**NEW DELHI:** Air India's board of directors held a meeting on Thursday amid the loss-making airline facing multiple headwinds, including high jet fuel prices, due to the West Asia conflict.

The board meeting took place at Air India's headquarters in Gurugram, Haryana.

The meeting started at around 11.30 am and went on for over three hours, according to sources. Specific details about the discussions at the meeting could not be ascertained. Earlier, sources had said the airline's financials for 2025–26, cost-saving measures and selection of a new CEO were expected to be discussed at the meeting.

Current CEO and MD Campbell Wilson will be stepping down later this year.

Airspace curbs and higher jet fuel prices due to the West Asia conflict are adversely impacting the airline, which is in the midst of an ambitious transformation plan. AGENCIES

## Cotton import duty hurting textile sector competitiveness: CITI study

AAISHA SABIR

**NEW DELHI:** The Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) on Thursday released a study urging the government to withdraw the 11 per cent import duty on cotton, saying the levy has weakened the price competitiveness of India's textile and apparel industry compared to Asian competitors that import cotton without duty.

The report, titled Economic Analysis of Cotton Supply, Pricing, and Trade Policy in India and prepared jointly by global consultancy Gherzi and the International Cotton Advisory Committee (ICAC), said intermittent relaxations in the duty structure have offered little relief.

The Centre had suspended the duty between August and December 2025 before reimposing it from January 1 this year.

According to the study,

such policy reversals disrupt mill planning and affect their ability to respond to market demand.

The report recommended empowering the Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) to supply cotton to domestic mills at international parity prices. It estimated that an annual buffer of nearly Rs 1,500 crore would be needed to provide around 100 lakh bales of Shankar-6 cotton, almost one-third of the crop, at rates four cents per pound below global prices.

It also suggested that the CCI maintain a strategic reserve equivalent to three months of domestic consumption to manage price volatility, similar to measures adopted by China.

CITI Chairman Ashwin Chandran said the report provides an “implementable roadmap” to help the industry achieve its target of becoming a \$350-billion sector by 2030, including \$100 billion

BASE YEAR REVISED TO 2022-23

# Govt issues uniform guideline for measuring GDP of states

*‘Guideline will provide standardised framework aimed to ensure consistency, comparability of state-level estimates’*

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** The statistics ministry on Thursday issued a uniform guideline for measuring states' gross domestic products (GSDP) with 2022–23 as the base year to ensure a standardised framework and comparability of performance across all states.

The base year for the calculation of national accounts has already been changed to 2022–23 to capture the current structure of the economy more accurately by incorporating modern data sources and improved estimation practices with evolving international standards.

In line with this change, states and Union Territories are required to adopt the new base year for compilation of Gross State Domestic Product



(GSDP) to ensure greater accuracy, consistency and comparability in assessing regional economic performance, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) said in a statement.

This guideline will provide a standardised framework aimed at ensuring consistency, reliability and comparability of state-level estimates, it said.

GSDP is extensively used by the Ministry of Finance, Finance Commission, Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) and other stakeholders for fiscal devolution, policy

At present, 34 states/UTs are compiling GSDP estimates with base year 2011-12

formulation, resource allocation, budgeting, performance assessment and inter-state comparisons.

At present, 34 states/UTs are compiling GSDP estimates with base year 2011–12, except Lakshadweep and Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu (DNH&DD). In the new series with base year 2022–23, the ministry said it is making concerted efforts to onboard all states/UTs, including Lakshadweep and DNH&DD, to ensure complete national coverage and uniformity in the compilation of regional accounts.

## Rupee rises 27 paise to 94.22 against US dollar

MPOST BUREAU

**MUMBAI:** The rupee pared initial losses and settled for the day on a positive note, higher by 27 paise at 94.22 against the greenback on Thursday, as Brent crude and the US dollar index retreated from their elevated levels.

Forex traders said Brent oil prices have fallen below USD 100 per barrel on a rise in investor risk appetite in global markets on hopes of peace between the US and Iran.

However, factors such as unabated foreign capital outflows and safe-haven dollar demand from importers capped sharp gains for the rupee.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee witnessed high volatility. It opened at 94.77 against the US dollar, registering a fall of 28 paise over its previous close.

In intraday trade, the USD/INR pair touched an intraday



low of 94.90 and a high of 94.08 against the American currency.

The rupee finally settled at 94.22 against the dollar, registering a rise of 27 paise over its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 69 paise to close at 97.86, down 0.16 per cent.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 97.86, down 0.16 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading lower by 2.23 per cent at USD 99.01 per barrel in futures trade.

## Gold, silver advance on weak dollar amid US–Iran peace hopes

*Silver prices jumped by Rs 7,000*

**NEW DELHI:** Gold prices rose further by Rs 600 to Rs 1.56 lakh per 10 grams in the local market here on Thursday, following a pullback in the US dollar and easing crude oil prices amid hopes for a US–Iran peace deal.

Silver prices jumped by Rs 7,000 to Rs 2,61,500 per kg on improved industrial demand, marking the fourth straight day of gains, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity gained Rs 600 to Rs 1,56,000 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from the previous close of Rs 1,55,400 per 10 grams. The metal had jumped Rs 2,900 per 10 grams on Wednesday.

Gold of 99.5 per cent purity traded at Rs 1,55,200 per 10 grams, according to the association.

Silver prices also advanced for the fourth consecutive day, surging by Rs 7,000 to Rs 2,61,500 per kg from the last close of Rs 2,54,500 per kg (inclusive of all taxes). The white metal had gained Rs 3,500 in the previous session.

“Gold extended its gains on Thursday as optimism around a potential US–Iran agreement continued to support sentiment across precious metals,” Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.



“Ongoing weakness in the US dollar drove additional support for precious metals. The dollar index traded below the 98 level. The pullback in the US dollar, influenced by market speculation regarding a potential US–Iran agreement to resolve the conflict, creates opportunities for easing monetary policy.”

The US dollar index was trading down 0.14 per cent at 97.88 on Thursday.

Brent crude oil prices dropped more than 3 per cent to USD 97.97 a barrel.

In global markets, gold rose for the third straight day, with the spot gold gaining 0.9 per cent to USD 4,734.28 an ounce. Spot silver prices raced over 5 per cent to USD 81.35 an ounce.

“The increase in precious metals is largely attributed to easing tensions in the Middle East, particularly surrounding the US–Iran conflict, which has lifted market sentiment and bolstered safe-haven demand,” Gaurav Garg, research analyst at Lemonn, said. AGENCIES

## Govt says 101 mineral blocks started ops since 2015

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** The government on Thursday said 101 auctioned mineral blocks have come into operation since the introduction of the auction regime in 2015.

The achievement underscores the transformative impact of reforms undertaken by the mines ministry in close coordination with state governments, contributing towards the vision of self-reliant India, the mines ministry said in a statement.

“The operationalisation of 101 blocks demonstrates the ministry's sustained focus not only on auctioning mineral resources but also on ensuring their timely transition into production,” it said.

Through continuous policy support, procedural streamlining, and active monitoring, the Ministry of Mines has worked closely with state governments to expedite statutory clearances, facilitate approvals, and address implementation challenges.

# CAG conducting special audit of 101 cities to assess ease of living: K Sanjay Murthy

*India hosting 3-day summit under overarching theme ‘Ease of Living with a Focus on Urban Mobility’*

**BENGALURU:** India is conducting a special audit of 101 cities to assess ease of living from the citizen's perspective, Comptroller and Auditor General K Sanjay Murthy said on Thursday.

In his inaugural address at the 5th BRICS Supreme Audit Institutions (SAI) Leaders' Summit here, Murthy also said the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India is auditing multi-modal transport and first-mile, last-mile logistics, in partnership with institutions like the Indian Institute of Technology and Indian Institute of Management, and the World Bank.

India is hosting the three-day summit under the overarching theme ‘Ease of Living with a Focus on Urban Mobility’.

Convened during India's year of BRICS Chairmanship 2026 by the Office of the CAG, the summit brings together 42 delegates, including Heads of SAI's from BRICS member countries, to deliberate on



audit themes of shared relevance, exchange best practices, and strengthen public financial oversight.

“There is something particularly fitting about gathering here in the city that India calls both its Silicon Valley and its Garden City. A city that writes the software powering the world's most advanced enterprises, and where, on the very same morning, a nurse boards an overcrowded bus for a ninety-minute commute to save lives that software cannot reach. Bengaluru, in that way, is not just a host city. It is the

living argument for why this summit matters,” Murthy said.

He said Indian cities today occupy just 3 per cent of the country's land, yet they contribute 60 per cent of the national GDP. By 2030, 70 per cent of all new jobs in India will be created in cities.

“Urban mobility is where governance stops being abstract and starts being personal. It is the daily referendum that citizens conduct on their governments, not at the ballot box, but at the bus stop,” he noted.

Global congestion indices have risen from 20 per cent to

CLOSER LOOK

» The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India is auditing multi-modal transport and first-mile, last-mile logistics

» He said Indian cities today occupy just 3 per cent of the country's land, yet they contribute 60 per cent of the national GDP

25 per cent as of 2025, costing each urban commuter between 100 and 180 hours of productive time every year.

“And yet, the solutions are not unknown,” the CAG said, adding that the barrier is governance.

He further said the urban mobility fails not for want of roads or rails, but for want of systems that work together.

“We build metro lines that don't connect to bus networks. We build flyovers that merely shift congestion. We measure outputs, kilometres of road laid, stations built, rather than out-

comes: did commute times fall? Did air quality improve? Did inequality in access reduce?” he added.

Talking about the evolving mandate of Supreme Audit Institutions, Murthy said that beyond traditional audit reports, the SAI India is now offering value-added products like departmental appreciation notes, management letters, and study reports.

“We are conducting a special audit of one hundred and one Indian cities, assessing ease of living from the citizen's perspective, across quality of life, access, sustainability, and perception,” he said.

Representing over 3 billion people and some of the world's fastest-growing urban populations, BRICS nations face common challenges, such as urban mobility, affordable housing, environmental sustainability, and equitable access to public services - areas where collective insights from SAIs can play a crucial role, the Office of CAG said in a release. AGENCIES

## ITC trains over 2,370 specially-abled youth for jobs in key sectors

MPOST BUREAU

**NEW DELHI:** From battling social stigma and mobility constraints in rural Andhra Pradesh to securing a job at Bengaluru's Kempegowda International Airport, 33-year-old Kavali Jyothi's journey reflects the transformative impact of skill development initiatives for persons with disabilities.

Jyothi, who has 65 per cent locomotor disability and hails from Anantapur district, now works as a Customer Support Associate earning Rs 16,000 per month, helping support her family while gaining financial independence and confidence. Her success, according to ITC, is part of a wider effort to create livelihood opportunities for specially-abled youth across the country. Similar stories have emerged from other states. Jayram Ramesh Sonune from Pune district, who has 40 per cent visual impairment, secured employment at Pune Airport after receiving training in computer proficiency, communication and

workplace readiness. He now earns Rs 25,000 per month. In Uttar Pradesh, Sunil Kumar from Barabanki, who has 90 per cent locomotor disability, is working as an accountant with a monthly salary of Rs 15,000.

The beneficiaries are part of ITC's skilling programme for persons with disabilities, which provides industry-relevant training, workplace readiness and support services such as sign-language interpretation and mentorship. The initiative also focuses on spoken English, workplace etiquette, digital literacy and financial literacy.

ITC said that in less than four years, more than 2,370 differently-abled youth have been trained under the programme, with women accounting for over 30 per cent of participants. Many have secured jobs in sectors including retail, hospitality, logistics, customer support and IT-enabled services.

Launched in Bengaluru in January 2023, the programme now operates through eight centres across Bengaluru, Mysuru, Lucknow, Howrah and Bhubaneswar.



'COMMITMENT TO STRENGTHENING MARITIME FLEET'

Govt extends subsidy scheme for cos flagging merchant ships until FY31

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The shipping ministry on Thursday extended the scheme for providing subsidies to Indian companies flagging merchant ships in India for five years until the financial year 2030-31.

The scheme for the promotion of flagging of merchant ships in India has been extended for a further period of five years, till FY 2030-31, reinforcing India's commitment to strengthening its maritime fleet and global shipping presence, the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways said in a statement.

In order to achieve the objective of Atmanirbhar Bharat, the Union Cabinet, in



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

July 2021, approved a scheme with an outlay of Rs 1,624 crore over five years for providing a subsidy to Indian shipping companies bidding for global tenders floated by ministries and central public sector enterprises for imports of govern-

ment cargoes. The scheme was announced by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman during her budget speech for FY22.

According to the scheme, for a ship flagged in India after February 1, 2021, which is less than 10 years old at the time of

HIGHLIGHTS

» The scheme reinforces India's commitment to strengthening its maritime fleet and global shipping presence, the Shipping ministry said in a statement

» In order to achieve the objective of Atmanirbhar Bharat, the Union Cabinet, in July 2021, approved the scheme with an outlay of Rs 1,624 cr over 5 yrs

offered by the L1 foreign company, whichever is less.

For existing Indian-flagged ships aged less than 10 years on February 1, 2021, the subsidy support would be extended at 10 per cent of the quote offered by the L1 foreign bidder, or the actual difference between the quote offered by the Indian-flagged vessel exercising ROFR and the quote offered by the L1 foreign company, whichever is less.

Ships older than 20 years are not eligible for any subsidy under the scheme.

In view of the enlarged scope of the scheme, the shipping ministry said it will seek allocation of additional funds from the Department of Expenditure if required.

Govt to bring postal logistics infrastructure plan for India Post: Min

Aims to upgrade the existing facilities in line with developed nations, he says

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government plans to introduce a postal logistics infrastructure plan for India Post to upgrade the existing parcel facilities in line with developed nations, Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said on Thursday.

After inaugurating the renovated building of Nehru Place Post Office, along with Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Minister of State for Communications Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani, Scindia said that world over, e-commerce has grown with digitisation and for further growth, the sector will need to use postal networks.

"Soon, with the blessings of the Prime Minister, with our department, with our family, we are going to bring a Postal Logistics Infrastructure Plan so that the logistics infrastructure, the way it is in advanced countries, of the supply-driven mechanism, of the input-output ratio, the same modern system, we will implement in India as well," he said.

India Post delivers 7.5 crore parcels per year, 90 crore letters, and till 2.12 crore passports and around 15 crore Aadhaar have been processed at post offices, he added.

The minister said that everyone needs to contribute to achieve the target set for achieving Viksit Bharat by 2047. Scindia said postmen play an important role in postal services, and they are well-connected with families in their areas.

The minister said there are

40 crore accounts in the Post Office Savings Bank in which people have deposited a total of Rs 23 lakh crore.

Pemmasani said the government has invested around Rs 5,800 crore in post office modernisation, which has enabled the start of OTP-based delivery, real-time SMS tracking to enhance transparency and convenience in postal services. "The greatest form of national strength is not only the military and economic power, but it is a citizen's trust in public infrastructure. With that, India Post, with 150 years of legacy, 1.6 lakh post offices, 4.5 lakh employees, and the love of every village, I think can prove that public sector institutions can be modern, can be accountable, and can be aspirational," he said.

Pemmasani said that various measures have been taken for the upgradation of work at post offices, including extension of working hours at post office hours so that people, working-class people can come in the evenings and avail its services, launched 24-hour, 48-hour services, speed post services across six major metros, among others. "We undertook the rationalisation of the post offices so that the network can become leaner, faster and more responsive to our citizens' needs. If you look at it, India Post revenue and the growth over the last 10 years, on average, we were growing around 200 to 300 crores over the last 10 years. And this year alone, we have increased our revenue by 2,100 crores. That's 10x," he said.

India's power demand to rise by '5 to 5.5%' in 2026-27, says ICRA

NEW DELHI: Rating agency ICRA on Thursday said power demand will rise by 5.0-5.5 per cent in 2026-27 as against a tepid one per cent growth in 2025-26, supported by continued momentum in industrial and commercial activity.

The country's power demand growth in 2026-27 is likely to be supported by agricultural and household sectors given the expectation of sub-par rainfall amidst a potential El Nino, along with demand from industries as well as from emerging sources like electric vehicles and data centres, ICRA said in a statement.

The all-India thermal plant load factor (PLF or capacity utilisation) level fell to 65-66 per cent in 2025-26 amid demand moderation and is likely to remain around 65 per cent in 2026-27, given the healthy growth in generation expected from the renewable



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

India's power demand growth in FY27 is likely to be supported by agri & household sectors

sources and 6-GW capacity addition likely in the thermal segment. Ankit Jain, Vice President & Co-Group Head - Corporate Ratings, ICRA, said in the statement that the thermal power sector in India is witnessing a revived investment emphasis, even as the renewable capacity continues to expand at a rapid pace.

Thermal power acts as a

reliable base-load supply, aiding grid stability, amid expectations of power demand growth, he said, adding that the coal stock level for the domestic power plants has been comfortable at around 19 days as on April 8, 2026.

The book losses of the distribution companies at the all-India level improved in 2024-25 over 2023-24. The gross debt for state-owned discoms reduced to Rs 7.1 trillion as of March 2025 from Rs 7.4 trillion as of March 2024, it stated. However, such high debt levels are unsustainable for discoms, given their current revenues and profitability, it pointed out.

The tariff orders for 2026-27 have been issued in 17 out of 28 states as of April 2026, it noted.

Despite the loss-making operations of discoms, tariff hikes approved for 2026-27 remain muted across most states, it pointed out. AGENCIES

INDIA'S PUSH TO BUILD A MORE INCLUSIVE MARITIME WORKFORCE

'Women's participation in maritime sector surges 340% since 2020'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Women's participation in India's maritime sector has increased by 340 per cent since 2020, Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal on Thursday said, underscoring the government's push to build a more inclusive, future-ready maritime workforce.

Delivering the keynote address at the 10th Indian Ocean Dialogue here, the Ports, Shipping and Waterways Minister highlighted "Nari Shakti" as a central pillar of India's maritime growth story.

"Through initiatives like 'Sagar Mein Samman', we are advancing dignity, inclusion



Union Minister for Ports Sarbananda Sonowal during the 10th Indian Ocean Dialogue in New Delhi

and leadership opportunities for women in the maritime sector, which has seen a remarkable rise of about 340 per cent since 2020," Sonowal said.

He also said that India

remains committed to working with all partners to advance a safe, secure and stable Indian Ocean Region.

The minister positioned the surge in women's partici-

pation within India's broader maritime vision, combining economic growth with social empowerment.

He noted that the "human element" remains central to India's maritime strategy, alongside efforts to enhance security, connectivity and sustainability.

"The Indian Ocean is not just a geographic space, but a global lifeline," Sonowal said, adding that its importance to global energy flows, trade and supply chains calls for stronger cooperation, resilience and inclusivity.

The 10th Indian Ocean Dialogue, hosted by India as Chair of the Indian Ocean Rim Asso-

ciation (IORA) for 2025-27, is themed "Indian Ocean Region in a Transforming World".

The forum brings together ministers, policymakers, academics and industry leaders to deliberate on maritime security, blue economy, disaster risk management and women's empowerment. Under India's Chair of IORA, the forum focuses on "Innovation, Openness, Resilience and Adaptability", with women's economic empowerment identified as a key cross-cutting priority area.

Sonowal also highlighted India's role as a "net security provider" in the region, pointing to initiatives in

humanitarian assistance, maritime surveillance and disaster response.

He stressed that no single country can address maritime challenges alone and called for collective action rooted in transparency and respect for international law.

"India remains committed to working with all partners to advance a safe, secure and stable Indian Ocean Region," Sonowal said.

The Indian Ocean Dialogue (IOD), IORA's flagship Track 1.5 platform launched in 2014 in Kochi, convenes ministers, policymakers, academics and industry leaders to deliberate on key regional issues.

Noida airport to begin ops with IndiGo flights to Lucknow, B'loru

NOIDA: IndiGo on Thursday announced that it will start commercial flight operations from the Noida International Airport in Jewar from June 15, becoming the launch carrier for the greenfield airport in western Uttar Pradesh.

The first day flights will be to and fro Lucknow and Bengaluru, the airline said in a statement.

Noida International Airport was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on March 28.

IndiGo said it will be the first carrier to start commercial services from the airport, the third in the National Capital Region (NCR).

According to the airline, inaugural flights on June 15 will operate on the Lucknow-Noida-Bengaluru-Noida-Lucknow sector.

As per the announced schedule, flight 6E 2278 will depart from Lucknow at 7.05 am and arrive in Noida at 8.05 am before departing for Bengaluru at 8.35 am and landing there at 11.05 am. AGENCIES

Need to raise fruit exports, focus on quality and shelf life to boost farmers' income: Agri minister

India among leading producers of mangoes, bananas, pomegranates, litchis and grapes

MPOST BUREAU

LUCKNOW: Union Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Thursday said India must significantly increase exports of fruits and vegetables by improving quality, shelf life, logistics and processing infrastructure to enhance farmers' income, create jobs and earn foreign exchange.

Addressing stakeholders during the two-day "Fruit Horizon 2026" programme at the ICAR-Central Institute for Subtropical Horticulture (CISH) in Lucknow, Chouhan said India can no longer remain focused only on production and must strengthen the entire value chain from farm to global markets.

"Farming can no longer remain limited to the fields. It is now necessary to strengthen the complete value chain from production to processing, marketing and exports," he said, according to an official statement.



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

The minister said India is currently producing 1,129.8 lakh metric tonnes of fruits, and nearly 71 lakh hectares of land are under fruit cultivation in the country.

"India is among the leading producers of mangoes, bananas, pomegranates, litchis and grapes. The quantity and quality of mangoes we produce are unmatched in the world, but our exports are still quite low," he said.

Chouhan said the government wants Indian fruits and vegetables to gain a stron-

ger foothold in international markets.

"If exports of our fruits and vegetables increase, farmers' incomes will rise, foreign exchange earnings will grow, and employment opportunities will expand," he said.

The minister stressed that improving fruit quality, increasing shelf life and maintaining quality during exports in line with international standards would now be a key focus area.

He said a task force comprising ICAR scientific insti-

KEY POINTS

» He was addressing stakeholders during the two-day 'Fruit Horizon 2026' programme at the ICAR-Central Institute for Subtropical Horticulture (CISH) in Lucknow

» Chouhan said India can no longer remain focused only on production and must strengthen the entire value chain from farm to global markets

rial for crops such as mango, guava, litchi and avocado.

Chouhan said India must focus on "zero rejection" and premium-quality fruit production to become globally competitive.

"Modern technology, better post-harvest management, pack houses, processing facilities and practical SOPs for exports can take Indian horticulture to new heights," he said.

The minister said the role of Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs), Farmer Producer Companies (FPCs) and self-help groups would be crucial in connecting small farmers with better markets and exports.

He also highlighted the importance of export-oriented clusters being developed by the National Horticulture Board and said initiatives linked to Jewar airport, including radiation and integrated post-harvest facilities, would strengthen export infrastructure in Uttar Pradesh.

Referring to cyber security concerns, he said Anthropic Mythos AI model has advanced capabilities to identify and potentially exploit systems, and added that it has raised alarm bells among regulators because of the vulnerabilities in legacy banking technology systems.

Nagaraju said banks and financial institutions remain highly vulnerable because of their interconnected systems, dependence on legacy IT infrastructure and real-time operations. "One successful cyber attack can cascade quickly

MUMBAI: DFS Secretary M Nagaraju on Thursday urged banks to strengthen their cyber security and operational resilience, cautioning that advanced artificial intelligence models such as Anthropic Mythos could pose significant risks to the banking system if released publicly. "I hope the banking community is prepared well to face in case Mythos is released publicly in the country," Nagaraju said, while addressing at the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) conference on Risk Management in Mumbai.

Referring to cyber security concerns, he said Anthropic Mythos AI model has advanced capabilities to identify and potentially exploit systems, and added that it has raised alarm bells among regulators because of the vulnerabilities in legacy banking technology systems.

Nagaraju said banks and financial institutions remain highly vulnerable because of their interconnected systems, dependence on legacy IT infrastructure and real-time operations. "One successful cyber attack can cascade quickly

across institutions and markets," he warned, stressing that operational continuity is now central to financial stability. Nagaraju said banks must continuously test their resilience, strengthen incident response mechanisms, invest in cyber capabilities and ensure that business continuity plans are practical, updated and regularly exercised.

Highlighting the broader risk environment, he said risks are no longer confined to trade books or balance sheets and now arise from geopolitical developments, cyber threats, operational disruptions, fraud, third-party dependencies, climate considerations, market volatility and changing customer behaviour. "In such an environment, risk management cannot be seen merely as an add-on to compliance or control functions, it must be viewed as a strategic capability," he said.

Nagaraju noted that the Indian banking sector has made significant progress in recent years with stronger balance sheets, improved asset quality, robust capital positions and enhanced governance standards. AGENCIES



India and the 27-nation bloc EU announced conclusion of negotiations for a FTA on January 27, which is touted as 'mother of all deals'

the EU and India should revisit this area two years down the road after the entry into force of the FTA, as envisaged in the review clause, to see whether we can find common ground and address this missing element of the investment liberalisation chapter," he said.

The ambassador also said both sides should promptly conclude the ongoing negotiation on investment protection agreement (IPA), which should give investors a solid legal framework and an additional incentive to expand their footprint in India.

He added that both political as well as the business constituencies are expecting this agreement.

"And to complete the picture, we should also swiftly conclude negotiations on the third agreement launched in parallel with the FTA and IPA, which is the agreement on geographical indications. And be sure that it will give also a boost to trade by ensuring proper protection of Indian and the EU's iconic products, whether Darjeeling cheese or Roquefort cheese," he said.

About 6,000 European firms are present in India.

The EU is already a leading investor in the country, with an

FDI stock of over 140 billion euros, and the stock of Indian investment in Europe stands at 440 billion euros.

"So the opportunities arising from the FTAs are pretty clear, and now the challenge is to turn these opportunities into achievements," he added.

Speaking at the event, India's chief negotiator for this FTA and Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce Darpan Jain said "we are working" on the investment thing.

"That is something which we plan to work on in future," Jain said.

Meanwhile, the ambassador added that under the FTA, the EU will eliminate or reduce duties on more than 99 per cent of Indian goods exports, while India will grant better access for almost 97 per cent of EU exports. "So we will have on the EU side European customers benefiting from cheaper Indian textiles, leather, footwear, gems, jewellery, tea, coffee, spices, marine products, to name a few. And Indian businesses will see lower prices on EU industrial goods like machinery, aircraft, or medical equipment," Delphin said. So customers at the end of the day will enjoy a wider choice and lower prices and businesses will save on lower tariffs and cheaper production inputs, he said, adding that both economies will benefit from trade diversification.

The bilateral trade in goods and services currently stands at over USD 190 billion.

"We have documented evidence that for every single FTA that the EU has had, the trade has grown twice faster than with partners with non-FTA. So we are confident that this also will happen with India. And think of it, it is estimated that EU's goods exports to India will double by 2032. And with preferential access to the EU market, Indian companies will be well positioned to significantly increase their sales to the EU," he said. AGENCIES



# Surface tension

Delhi Capitals batters face stern spin test from Varun-Narine duo

NEW DELHI: Unable to negotiate tricky batting tracks or defend big totals on belters, there seems no comfort even on home turf for Delhi Capitals when they take on Kolkata Knight Riders in a must-win IPL game here on Friday.

Delhi Capitals, currently in seventh position with eight points from 10 games, need to win all four of their remaining games to reach 16 points and sneak into the playoffs.

The eighth-placed KKR need to win all five of their remaining matches to leapfrog to 17 points in order to remain relevant.

In this backdrop, what becomes important is the surface on which DC will play the game. It is understood that to counter the threat of spin twins Sunil Narine and Varun Chakravarthy, DC is likely to opt for a batting belter and will be playing on Pitch No.6, the track on which they scored 264 but failed to defend against Punjab Kings.

The reason for picking such a track is lack of faith in the batting line-up which was reduced to 9 for 6 on a slightly seaming surface against the Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

On a slowish surface where the ball gripped, the DC batters failed to come to terms



Delhi Capitals' KL Rahul during a practice session on the eve of the match

PTI

with Rashid Khan of Gujarat Titans, and Akeal Hosein and Noor Ahmed of the Chennai Super Kings.

Sunil (Economy Rate of 6.80) and Varun (Economy Rate 8.88) can make life miserable for the likes of Pathum Nissanka, Sameer Rizvi, and Karun Nair to name a few.

Making things worse for Delhi is premier spinner Kuldeep Yadav (10 matches, 7 wickets at ER 10.36), who is going through his worst IPL season right now.

In such a situation, the only escape route for a distinctly mediocre team with no apparent 'Plan B' is to play on a flat deck.

It would give the non-per-

forming home batters a chance to pile up a big score. Later, the team would expect that Mitchell Starc and Lungi Ngidi, who suffered a concussion during the game against Punjab, would seal the deal with the ball.

The only advantage DC will have is that KKR's pain point is also its top order performance.

The two main batters at the top, skipper Ajinkya Rahane (205 runs at Strike Rate 131.42) and Angkrish Raghuvanshi (268 runs at 137.43) haven't been able to grab the initiative in most of the games.

Save Rinku Singh (245 runs at 145.39), who has done the heavy lifting in KKR wins, the other batters have mostly struggled.

If KKR are still in with a chance to progress, it is because of Narine and Varun who have got 9 and 10 wickets respectively.

For DC, the problems have been way too many.

KL Rahul, with his best ever IPL strike rate of 180 plus in an aggregate of 445 runs, has put in an effort. But his his best isn't enough given that the likes of Abhishek Sharma, and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi are striking at way above 200.

The team management's insistence on continuing with Pathum Nissanka (228 in nine games) has been baffling.

Playing Karun Nair, who has been in horrible touch even in the nets, defied logic. AGENCIES

'Bumrah is trying too many things'

NEW DELHI: Senior India pacer Umesh Yadav says Jasprit Bumrah has been trying too many things and that is the reason for his inconsistent run this IPL, while experienced seamer Bhuvneshwar Kumar has succeeded because of his clear planning and ability to deliver in both Powerplay and death overs.

Bhuvneshwar is so far the highest wicket-taker in the ongoing IPL with 17 wickets from nine games for RCB, while on the other hand Mumbai Indians' Bumrah has struggled, picking up just three scalps from 10 games.

"Bhuv's and is his team's planning is clear. He bowls in Powerplay and death, and his game plan is set. He is able to swing in both ways," said Umesh. "Bhuv is consistent with his line, length and variation and Bumrah is trying a lot of things which is creating problems for him." AGENCIES

## Women enter WC semis with South Korea upset; men bow out

SHANGHAI: India endured a mixed day at the Archery World Cup Stage 2 as the women's recurve team assured the country's first medal with a stunning semifinal win over record 10-time Olympic champion South Korea, but the men's team suffered a disappointing exit after a shock defeat against Bangladesh, here Thursday.

India's campaign also ended in the mixed team event where the duo of Dhiraj Bommadevara and Ankita Bhakat lost to Brazil in the second round.

The women's team of seasoned Deepika Kumari, Ankita Bhakat and teenager Kumkum Mohod defeated a new-look Korean side 5-1 in the semifinals to set up a gold medal clash against second seed China on Sunday. But there was embarrassment for the men's recurve team as veteran Tarundeep Rai, Dhiraj Bommadevara and Yashdeep Bhoghe failed to win a single set in a below-par 2-6 defeat to Bangladesh.

The women's team maintained composure throughout a demanding day in which they won three consecutive matches. The fourth-seeded Indians started strongly in the semifinal, shooting four 10s from six arrows and dropping just two points to take the opening set with a superb 58. The Koreans looked unsettled and managed only 55.

India slipped slightly in the



Deepika Kumari led India to 5-1 win over Korea in the semis

FILE

### But the win came against an inexperienced Korean line-up

second set with an 8 but still managed to tie at 56-56 and move 3-1 ahead.

Needing just two more points to seal the match, the Indians again shot 58 in the third set, while the Koreans faltered under pressure and managed 56, handing India a memorable straight-set victory.

But the win came against an inexperienced Korean line-up which was fielded as part of their preparations for the Asian Games in Japan, less than four months away.

The Korean team featured two debutants in Lee Yunji and Oh Yejin, while reigning

world champion Kang Chaeyoung was the only experienced archer in the side. Olympics champions An San and Lim Sihyeon, along with last year's Shanghai gold medallist Lee Gahyun, were absent.

In contrast, the men's team produced a forgettable performance against Bangladesh.

The Indian trio, which qualified as the eighth seed, struggled for consistency and failed to win a single set in four rounds. In the opening set, India shot three 8s and managed only 52, while Bangladesh shot 55 to take a 2-0 lead.

India again lacked composure in the second set and another seven pushed them to 54. Bangladesh also shot poorly but managed to tie the set 54-54 and extend their lead to 3-1. The third set was another low-quality affair with both teams shooting 53 each. AGENCIES

## 'WE WIN AND LOSE TOGETHER' Amid Capitals' slide, Miller urges for unity



David Miller during a practice session on Thursday

PTI

NEW DELHI: Senior South Africa batter David Miller said that Delhi Capitals squad has consciously stayed away from blaming individuals and remains united in its bid to pull off a late surge into the IPL playoffs.

Having endured a difficult phase marked by batting collapses and costly fielding lapses, Delhi now find themselves in a must-win situation heading into the final stretch of the league stage.

DC now needs to win all four remaining games in order to stay in contention for play offs. "We are in a position where we have spoken that it is all of us together. Win or lose, we are together," Miller said ahead of game against Kolkata Knight Riders.

"And there is no pointing any fingers at all with what we have done. We are all in it together," Miller added.

Stressing that the qualification equation is straightforward for the side now, he added: "The reality is we have got four games to win. So if we do that, then we are putting ourselves in a good position."

Speaking about Delhi's recent defeats, Miller felt the team has not played poor

**"We are in a position where we have spoken that it is all of us together. Win or lose, we are together"**

David Miller

cricket overall but has faltered in crucial moments.

"I do not think we have been playing bad cricket at all. We have been playing really good cricket, but there are just moments in the game where we have kind of let ourselves down as a team in certain areas."

Reflecting on his own stop-start season and limited opportunities in the playing XI, Miller admitted it has been frustrating but said he understands the dynamics of the IPL.

"Not being able to play, obviously it is frustrating as a player. You always want to play every game, but such is the IPL, the structure of it with only four overseas, the combinations become really important for the team," he said. AGENCIES

## U-17 Asian Cup: Eves eye history

SUZHOU: Having lost to two continental heavyweights, India face a must-win game against Lebanon in the AFC U17 Women's Asian Cup here on Friday, knowing that victory could seal a first-ever qualification to the knockout stage of the competition.

After losing to Australia (0-2) and Japan (0-3) in Group B, the equation for India has become clear: one final match and one final chance to make the quarter-finals.

India are alive in the race for the knockout stage as one of the two best third-placed teams. India currently hold a superior goal difference of -5 compared to Group C sides Philippines (-13) and Chinese Taipei (-14), who face each other on the final matchday.

That means either side would require a heavy-margin victory to overtake India's goal difference if the Young Tiggers defeat Lebanon.

Furthermore, if Thursday evening's Group A fixture between Vietnam and Myanmar ends in a draw or the latter wins by less than three goals, India will confirm their place in the last eight with a victory, irrespective of the Group C result. AGENCIES

## Varun's quality never in question, KKR mentor Bravo backs spinner

NEW DELHI: Kolkata Knight Riders bowling coach and mentor Dwayne Bravo believes the franchise's unwavering faith in mystery spinner Varun Chakravarthy has played a crucial role in his return to form during the ongoing IPL season.

Chakravarthy has been one of KKR's standout performers in an otherwise dull season, with 10 wickets at an economy rate of under nine.

Bravo said the team never doubted the spinner's ability despite a lean phase earlier in the tournament.

"Yeah, I think in sports, it's very result orientated and sometimes people get very emotional. So a player like Varun, who is a world-class spinner, just came out from the World Cup which was also a very hectic tournament," Bravo said on the eve of the IPL match against Delhi Capitals here.

Chakravarthy required a break but his skill set was never under scanner. "So a break at the right time is always important but no one ever questioned his ability because again, when you are so good it's only a matter of time before you come back into form," Bravo said.

Emphasising the importance of mental recovery dur-



Varun Chakravarthy and Umran Malik mess with Kuldeep Yadav

PTI

### Chakravarthy has been one of KKR's standout performers in an otherwise dull season, with 10 wickets to his name

ing a demanding IPL season, Bravo said the KKR dressing room ensured Chakravarthy felt supported throughout the difficult phase.

"The group is very supportive of him and a mental break is also very needed especially in a tournament like IPL that has so many games, high pressure, the best versus the best. So yeah, no

matter who you are as a player, you see that there are so many other quality players struggling this season and I think that's the beauty of the sport. Players have to go through those moments, but eventually they will bounce back," he said.

Bravo, regarded as one of the pioneers of death bowling variations in T20 cricket, also spoke about the craft behind delivering an effective slower ball and said execution alone is not enough without game awareness. "Yeah, I'm very hands-on. Everyone wants me to teach them that slower ball. "It's one of my strengths when I used to play. But also what was my strength was my ability to read and understand the game." AGENCIES

## Sinner adds his voice to French Open prize money protests

ROME: The top tennis players are already upset they are not receiving a bigger share of tournament revenues at the French Open. Now they're hoping Wimbledon and the US Open respond to their demands, according to Jannik Sinner.

Fellow No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka said this week the players should consider a boycott.

"It's more about respect. Because I think we give much more than what we are getting back," Sinner said on Thursday at the Italian Open.

"It's not only for the top players; it's for all of us players." Sinner wouldn't commit to a boycott.

"It's tough to say," he said. "I cannot predict the future in a way. But in the same time I also believe that somewhere we need to start."

The players have targeted the upcoming French Open for reducing players' share of revenue to an alleged 15 per cent — compared to the 22 per cent at ATP and WTA events like the Italian Open this week.

The same group of players sent a letter a year ago to the heads of the four Grand Slams seeking more prize money and a greater say in decision-making. Wimbledon increased its



2025 total pot by 7 per cent, the US Open by 20 per cent and the Australian Open in January by 16 per cent.

"It's not nice that after one year we are not even close to conclusion of what we would like to have," Sinner said.

"I truly believe that within 48 hours you have not only a response but you also have a meeting."

French Open organisers announced last month they were increasing overall prize money by about 10 per cent for an overall pot of 61.7 million euros (USD 72.1 million), with the total amount up 5.3 million euros from last year. But the players' statement said "the underlying figures tell a very different story," claiming they will receive a smaller share of tournament revenues. AGENCIES

## Can Vinesh compete in comeback event?

NEW DELHI: Wrestler Vinesh Phogat's eligibility to return to competitive wrestling remains under a cloud ahead of the National Open Ranking Tournament in Gonda due to ambiguity over her compliance with the World Anti-Doping Agency's mandatory six-month notice rule for athletes coming out of retirement.

Vinesh announced her retirement from the sport after the 2024 Paris Olympics heartbreak but expressed her desire to return to competition in December last year. She has entered the open ranking tournament, in 57kg.

However, it remains unclear whether the former world championships medalist has fulfilled the requirements laid down under WADA's Article 5.6.1, which governs the return of retired athletes to competition. The rule states that an athlete in a Registered Testing Pool (RTP) -- a select group of elite athletes subject to no-notice doping tests -- who retires and later wishes to return to active participation must make himself or herself available for testing by giving a six-month prior written notice to the concerned International federation and national anti-doping organisation. AGENCIES

## UCL: Kvaratskhelia creative spark as PSG reach second straight final

MUNICH: Whether scoring or creating, Khvicha Kvaratskhelia makes the difference for Paris Saint-Germain.

His team-leading 10 goals have played a huge part in helping titleholder PSG reach a second straight Champions League final.

His superb assist put PSG ahead early in a 1-1 draw at Bayern Munich on Wednesday for a 6-5 aggregate win against the six-time champions. That came after the 25-year-old Georgia star's two goals helped PSG win the first leg 5-4.

Kvaratskhelia was irreplaceable in the semifinals, as he was against Monaco, Chelsea and Liverpool earlier in the Champions League campaign.

His awareness led to PSG's goal three minutes into the return leg and put Bayern on the back foot immediately,



Khvicha Kvaratskhelia has been instrumental in PSG's campaign

AP

when many observers expected PSG to struggle early on.

Kvaratskhelia even started the move that led to PSG's goal.

Catching Bayern's midfield napping by dropping deep, he then released Fabian Ruiz with a brilliant flick with the outside

**1**  
PSG have become the first French team to reach three different European Cup/UCL finals

of his right foot.

He then spun around to collect Ruiz's excellent first-time pass before sprinting down the left and picking out Dembélé with a fine pass across the

penalty area. Dembélé shot powerfully into the roof of the net for his seventh goal of the competition.

Bayern had some spells of possession but never recovered from the early blow and, at the end, Kvaratskhelia's boundless energy and runs almost led to another PSG goal.

"We have a magnificent team, a young team, we fight together," PSG president Nasser Al-Khelaifi said. "We have stars but everyone fights. Look at the last minute, Kvara is cooked (but) kept fighting."

Dembélé was PSG's key player last season, and now it could be Kvaratskhelia's turn to shine when PSG faces Arsenal in the final on May 30.

"We're very happy, we know it will be very difficult against Arsenal," Kvaratskhelia said. AGENCIES



30.5 m x 2 x 30.5 m) & bearing inspection & location planning around pier no. 01 to 17 & abutment No. 01 & 02 of BR. No. 7DB Span (3x18.3 m x 2x30.5 m x 3x18.3 m) under SSE/BR/MA. **Approx. Cost (Rs.): 13,21,09,33/-** **Earnest Money to be deposited (Rs.): 26,42,00,00/-**

**Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of tender:** The tender uploaded on 04.05.2026 online on [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) and the date of tender opening is 28.05.2026 and will be opened on the same day after 13:00 hrs. **Website particulars, notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.:** Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: <http://www.ireps.gov.in> & full details of notice can be seen on notice board. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website if required.

**Executive Engineer/ Bridge/Line East Central Railway, Danapur**

PR/0180/DNR/ENR/GT-26-2796

# NORTHERN RAILWAY

## NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION

r/Freight, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, in terms of Railway Board letter no. /Freight/2024/RD/167 dated: 13.08.2024, invites e- bidders for leasing of parcel space of **SLR compartments** and VPs (on round trip basis) for a duration given below -

| Assets to be auctioned                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| (F1), 12452 (F1), 12457(F1,F2,R1), 12952(F1), 14004 (F1), 14087(F1,F2,R1), 14093(F1,F2,R1), 14507 (F1,F2,R1), 14521(F1,F2,R1), 14731(F1,R1), 20408 (F1), 22421(R1), 12612 (F1), 12642 (F1), 12916 (F1), 12958 (F1), 12986(F1), 13258(F1), 14053 (F2), 14061(F1), 15622(F1), 20473 (F1), 20658 (F1), 22210(R1), 22429(F1), 22438(R1), 22454 (F1) |
| e) on round trip basis in each train - 12454/12453, 14012/14011, 14050/14049,                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

requirement and various aspects regarding these e-Auctions, interested bidders are to visit [in/html/helpdesk/learning\\_centre.html](#), (**e-Auction\_Leasing\_section**). 4. Railway authorities reserve the right to short terminate these contracts at any point of time and/or for taking any other action as may be required under the provisions of the Railways Act, 1989 and its subsequent amendments notwithstanding the continuation of these contracts with modified/additional terms and conditions depending upon the requirements of the railway concerned.

**1519/2026**

### SERVING COMMUTERS WITH A SMILE

**APPENDIX IV-A**

**Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property**

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and with price of Rs. 206.80 Lakhs (Rupees Two Hundred Sixty Thousand Eight Hundred) only, as per the terms of the Sale Agreement dated 11.06.2026. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **Sammaal Capital Limited (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.)** [CIN : L65922DL2005PL136029] ("Secured Creditor"), the constructive possession of which was held by the Applicant as the Authorized Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 11.06.2026 from 12.00 PM to 06.00 PM, for recovery of Rs. 25,50,00,584/- (Rupees Twenty Five Lakh Fifty Thousand Five Hundred Ninety Four only) pending towards Loan Account No. HLLRHNN0514849, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 30.04.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 01.05.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from **ROSHAN KUMAR MISHRA AND REETA DEVI**.

The Reserve Price of the Immovable Property will be Rs. 20,00,00,00/- (Rupees Twenty Lakh only) and the Cash/ Cash Deposit ("EMD") to be Rs. 2,00,00,00/- (Rupees Two Lakh only) i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

**DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY**

**ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL OF THE FIRST FLOOR, HAVING AREA OF 43.33 SQ. YARDS OUT OF TOTAL AREA MEASURING 130.67 SQ. YARDS, FRONT RIGHT NORTHERN EASTERN PORTION, WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS, IN THE BUILT - UP PROPERTY BEARING NO. 182 OUT OF KHASRA NO. - 335, GALI NO. 8, T-EXTN., IN THE VILLAGE BINDAPUR AND THE COLONY KNOWN AS T-EXTN., UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI - 110059, WITH TWO WHEELER PARKING RIGHTS AND TWO STOPS ON THE GATE, COMMON USE OF LIFT ALONGWITH PROPORTIONATE UNDIVIDED / INDIVISIBLE AND IMPARTIBLE OWNERSHIP RIGHTS IN THE UNDERNEATH LAND, WITH ALL RIGHTS, TITLE, INTEREST IN THE SAID PROPERTY.**

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. [www.sammaalcapital.com](http://www.sammaalcapital.com); Contact No : 0124 - 6910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id : [auctionhelpline@sammaalcapital.com](mailto:auctionhelpline@sammaalcapital.com). For bidding, log on to [www.auctionfocus.in](http://www.auctionfocus.in).

**sd/-**  
**AUTHORISED OFFICER**  
**SAMMAAL CAPITAL LIMITED**  
(Formerly known as)

**Date: 30.04.2026**  
**Place : NEW DELHI** **INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.**

# NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender No. PRYJ-Sig-008-2026-27

Date: 05.05.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Senior Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Coordination (North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite **E-TENDER** on prescribed form for the following works up to **12.00 hrs.** on the opening date of **E-Tender** mentioned therein. The details of the Tender are as under:-

| S.N.                                  | Tender No.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Name of Work                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1                                     | 008                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | S&T Works in c/w (A) Prayagraj Division- Provision of stabling lines at Subedarganj station. (B) Construction of a new island platform at Subedarganj (SFG) by dismantling at line No. 2 & 3 along with retaining of existing P/F No. 6. |
|                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <div style="display: flex; justify-content: space-between;"> <div>Approx. Cost of work: 29235681.14</div> <div>Earnest Money: 584700/-</div> </div>                                                                                      |
|                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <div style="display: flex; justify-content: space-between;"> <div>Cost of Tender Form: 0.00</div> <div>Completion Period: 12 Months</div> </div>                                                                                         |
| Date of Opening of tender: 02.06.2026 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 2                                     | <b>Availability of tender form</b> Tender forms are available on <a href="http://www.ireps.gov.in">www.ireps.gov.in</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 3                                     | <b>Earnest Money to be deposited:</b> The prescribed amount of Bid Security as mentioned above must be deposited along with the tender form Online through Internet Banking or Online Payment gateway only. The tenderer(s) should note that, in any case, the Bid Security in any other form than specified in GCC shall be acceptable. If the Bid Security deposited by the bidder is in shape of Bank Guarantee, it should be supported by proper stamp duty, price, prescribed as per section 13 & 24 of the UP Stamp Act, 2008 and amended from time to time at the time of submission of Bank Guarantee. Tenders without Bid Security shall be summarily rejected. |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 4                                     | Time & place of opening of tender                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Tender will be opened through E-tender at office of Divisional Railway Manager, Prayagraj at or after 12:30 hrs. In case tender opening date happens to be holiday, Tenders will be opened on the next working day.                      |
| 5                                     | Validity of offer                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | 60 days from the date of opening.                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 6                                     | Right of Railway to deal with tender.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Railway administration reserves the rights to postpone/ modify or to cancel the tender without assigning any reasons. <div style="text-align: right;">1005/26 (ADM)</div>                                                                |

North central railways

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

@ CPRONCR

# NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Procurement Tender Notice No. 26/17

Date : 05.05.2026

## E-Procurement Tender Notice

On behalf of the President, in India, The Principal Chief Material Manager, North Central Railway, Prayagraj (An ISO 9001:2015 certified unit) invites the following E-Procurement Tenders.

| Tender No. | Short Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Qty.       | Tender Opening Date |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|---------------------|
| 30261752   | 203.2 MM x 95.25 MM BOGIE MOUNTED AIR BRAKE CYLINDER                                                                                                                                                                                    | 1460 Nos.  | 19.05.2026          |
| 30252878   | FLEX BALL CALE LONG                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 80 Nos.    | 22.05.2026          |
| 30262804   | BOGIE BOLSTER ARRANGEMENT                                                                                                                                                                                                               | 64 Nos.    | 28.05.2026          |
| 30262601   | HIGH TENSILE TIGHT LOCK CENTRE BUFFER COUPLER                                                                                                                                                                                           | 775 Nos.   | 28.05.2026          |
| 38621468   | CUT OFF ANGLE COCK WITH VENT                                                                                                                                                                                                            | 7751 Nos.  | 02.06.2026          |
| 6326RGC08A | This is tender to enter into Rending Contract for the Manufacture and Supply of 6400 mm Over riding rail bearings with curved long tail BG (1773 mm) for use on R-260 Grade (Prime Quality) on PSC sleeper as per RD50 Drg. No. T-0608. | 250.00 Set | 01-Jun-26           |
| 60255033A  | Universal Fatigue testing Machine                                                                                                                                                                                                       | 1 Nos.     | 26.05.2026          |
| 30261691   | DISTRIBUTOR VALVE WITH RELAY VALVE FOR AIR BRAKE SYSTEM                                                                                                                                                                                 | 135 Nos.   | 28.05.2026          |
| 30261654   | INJECTION MOULDED THERMOPLASTIC POLYESTER ELASTOMER (HYTREL) AXLE BOX FRONT COVER                                                                                                                                                       | 2125 Nos.  | 04.06.2026          |
| 38262251   | BOGIE CENTRE PIVOT BOTTOM                                                                                                                                                                                                               | 5627 Nos.  | 25.05.2026          |
| 30262229   | UIC TYPE RUBBER VESTIBULE ARRANGEMENT                                                                                                                                                                                                   | 422 Nos.   | 28.05.2026          |
| 20263114   | Set (Motor set) of MP/CP coils                                                                                                                                                                                                          | 31 Set.    | 01.06.2026          |
| 20263659   | Set of Shaft and assembled dummy pinion.                                                                                                                                                                                                | 351 Set.   | 02.06.2026          |
| 20262646   | Fully Machined Shaft for hitachi T.M. Armature                                                                                                                                                                                          | 196 Nos.   | 08.06.2026          |
| 20261310   | BRAKE WEAR PLATE                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | 15747 Nos. | 28.05.2026          |

**Note :** The complete information of above tenders can be seen/downloaded from IREPS website i.e. <https://www.ireps.gov.in>. For any any change/corrigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No separate corrigendum/change will be published in news paper.

100226 (C)


[www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in](https://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in)

[www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in](https://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in)


## NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

**T. Notice No. GSU/Elect/PRY/J-E-Tender Notice/2026/64 Date : 06.05.2026**

**Tender Notice**

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/GSU/N.C. Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E- Tender, the details of the tenders are as under:

**Tender No-:** GSU-EL-WC-78-2026, **Description of work:** 25 kV OHE modification work in GMC yard due to Development of GMC as satellite station in Prayagraj division.

|                                                                 |                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Advertised value:</b> ₹ 2, 71, 14, 718.64                    | <b>Bid Security:</b> ₹ 5,42,300.00    |
| <b>Completion Period :</b> 12 Months                            | <b>Bidding system :</b> Single Packet |
| <b>Tender Closing date &amp; Time :</b> 28.05.2026 & 14.00 Hrs. |                                       |
| <b>Tender Opening date &amp; Time :</b> 28.05.2026 & 15.00 Hrs. |                                       |

**Note:-** (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders shall be available on Website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) 21days prior to the date of opening of the tender. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate. (3) In case of any difficulty helpline available on the website of IREPS may be approached.

**100926 (MG)**

North central railways

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www.nc.indianrailways.gov.in

# PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

**(See Section 34 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shahnawaz Khan, S/o Mohd. Saeed Khan R/o H.No.1737, Gali Hanif Wali, Near Chandi Mahal PS, House Suwalan, Daryaganj, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.639/2021 u/s 380/454/411/34 IPC, P.S. Sadar Bazar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Shahnawaz Khan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Shahnawaz Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shahnawaz Khan** of **FIR No.639/2021 u/s 380/454/411/34 IPC, P.S. Sadar Bazar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.07.2026**.

**By Order,**  
**Sh. Kartik Taparia**  
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06, Central District  
Room No.247, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/5884/N/2026

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| <h2 style="margin: 0;">NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY</h2>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                    |
| <b>File No. :-</b> GeM/Bid/Sr.DEN/IV/2026-27                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Date :-</b> 04.05.2026          |
| <b>E-Tendering Tender Notice</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                    |
| <p>Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS on GeM in prescribed form for the following work up to <b>11:00 hrs. on 28.05.2026</b>. The details of the Tender are as under:-</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                    |
| <p><b>S.N. :- 1, GeM Bid No.:-</b> GEM/2026/B/7491661, <b>Name of work:</b> Custom Bid for Services Rendering annual service for maintenance of Civil Engineering works of Tundla Excluding to Chipiyana Buzurg including Hathras for 2 Years in the section of SrDEN IV PRYJ.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                    |
| <b>Approx. Cost of work:</b> ₹ 53,08,298.28                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Bid Security:</b> ₹ 1,06,200.00 |
| <p><b>S.N. :- 2, GeM Bid No.:-</b> GEM/2026/B/7492442, <b>Name of work:</b> Custom Bid for Services Rendering annual service for maintenance of Civil Engineering Works of Tundla colony service building Yamuna pipe line etc at Tundla under ADEN Estate TDL for 02 years in the section of SrDEN IV PRY.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                    |
| <b>Approx. Cost of work:</b> ₹ 75,89,325.72                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Bid Security:</b> ₹ 1,51,800.00 |
| <b>Completion Period: For S.No. 1 to 2:- 02 Years</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                    |
| <b>Date and time of Opening of tender: For S.No. 1 to 2:- 28.05.2026 at 11:30</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                    |
| <b>Eligibility Criteria for similar work: For S.No. 1 to 2: Any Civil Engineering Work</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                    |
| <p>(1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-TENDER is available GeM Portal up to 11:00 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e., <b>28.05.2026</b>. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with GeM Portal. (3) The tenders shall submit a copy of certificate as given in tender document in standard format, without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. (4) In case of any difficulty helpline available on the website of GeM may be approached. (5) The tenderer has to submit necessary documents in compliance of GCC for services 2018 mandatorily, otherwise offer will be considered as Incomplete offer and accordingly shall not be considered.</p> |                                    |
| <b>993/26 (MC)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                    |
| North central railways                  @CPNCR                  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                    |



# PRIYANKA TEAMS UP WITH Orlando for 'Reset'

**'Rest' will feature Priyanka as a woman who wakes up in the middle of the wilderness, days from civilisation, with no memory of how she got there**

**The movie will be directed by Matt Smukler**

LOS ANGELES: Priyanka Chopra Jonas has found her next Hollywood film in 'Reset', a survival thriller which will feature her alongside 'Pirates of the Caribbean' star Orlando Bloom. The movie, which will go into production in August, will be directed by Matt Smukler, best known for the 2020 drama film 'Wildflower'.

'Reset' will feature Priyanka as a woman who wakes up in the middle of the wilderness, days from civilisation, with no memory of how she got there. Her only chance of survival is to trust a charming stranger, who may not be who he claims to be.

Smukler told 'Deadline' that the pairing was driven by the actors' rare ability to project attraction and mistrust simultaneously. "I was looking for a pairing where attraction and mistrust could effortlessly coexist. Priyanka and Orlando have this uncanny ability to make you believe both at once. Their chemistry is undeniable," he said.

The film will be produced by Jon Hoeber and Erich Hoeber under their 'Fratricidal Films' banner, Michael Lazarovitch for 'Chemically Altered' and Matthew Rhodes of 'Rhodes Entertainment'.

Chopra Jonas' 'Purple Pebble Pictures' and Bloom's 'Amazing Owl' are also on board, with Nadine de Barros serving as executive producer. She was last seen in 'The Bluff', an action-adventure film which also starred 'The Boys' actor Karl Urban. She previously starred alongside Idris Elba and John Cena in 'Heads of State'.

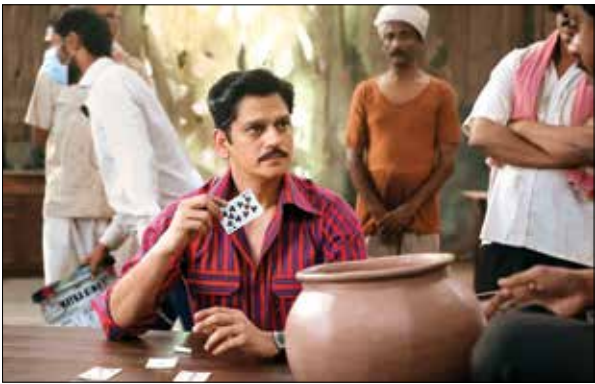
Through 'Purple Pebble Pictures', she has executive produced several acclaimed projects, including the Oscar-nominated Netflix film 'The White Tiger', in which she also starred, the Oscar-nominated short 'Anuja' and the Oscar-nominated doc-

umentary 'To Kill a Tiger'.

She currently stars in season two of her action series 'Citadel' and will be next seen in 'Varanasi', an action-adventure film directed by S S Rajamouli.

## 'Matka King' is set to return for Season 2!

*The second season is all about where the real stakes begin*



### OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video' announced season two of its breakout 'Original' drama series, 'Matka King', is in development following the massive success of season one. Set against the fast-changing backdrop of 1960s Bombay, the high-stakes drama struck a powerful chord with audiences through its gripping narrative of ambition, power and identity, brought to life with compelling performances and immersive storytelling.

The first season emerged as the most-watched new scripted series on the service in the last two years, trending in the 'Top 10' across 37 countries and ranking #1 in 17 countries within its opening week. Garnering widespread acclaim from viewers, the series has reinforced that rooted authentic stories resonate deeply with audiences in India and worldwide.

Created and written by Abhay Koranne and created, written and directed by Nagraj Popatrao Manjule, the eight-episode series of season one was led by the dynamic Vijay Varma, alongside Kritika Kamra, Sai Tamhankar, Siddharth Jadhav, Bhupen-



**The game of 'Matka' is far from over and neither is Brij Bhatti's reign**

dra Jadawat and Gulshan Grover in pivotal roles, supported by a talented ensemble cast including Bharat Jadhav, Girish Kulkarni, Jamie Lever, Kishor Kadam, Cyrus Sahukar, Arpita Sethiya, Sambhaji Tangade, Ishiyak Khan, Sanjiv Jotangia and Simran Ashwini in pivotal roles, bringing depth and authenticity to the narrative.

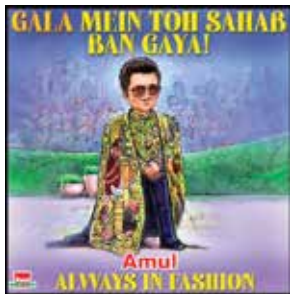
The game of 'Matka' is far from over and neither is Brij Bhatti's reign. 'Matka King' season two is where the real stake begins!

## KJo conquered the Met, now Amul has made it official

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

Karan Johar's 'Met Gala' debut has earned him perhaps the most quintessentially Indian seal of approval - an 'Amul' topical.

The iconic dairy brand, known for its witty illustrated tributes to India's most culturally significant moments, celebrated Johar's historic appearance at the 2026 Met Gala with a topical that captures his show-stopping Manish Malhotra-designed outfit in full illustrated glory, complete with the tagline: 'Gala Mein Toh Sahab Ban Gaya!' - and the brand's signature sign-off, "Always In Fashion."



19th-century painter widely regarded as the father of modern Indian art. Hand-painted across 86 days by over 80 'kari-gars', the look was India in every sense: its art, its craft, its heritage and its hands. For a country that has long known the depth of its own cultural legacy, seeing it finally receive its due on the world's most-watched fashion stage was a moment of quiet, collective pride.

What made the moment even more resonant was what Johar chose to carry onto that carpet. His custom Manish Malhotra creation, titled 'Framed in Eternity', was a deeply personal tribute to Raja Ravi Varma, the

Johar himself reacted to the topical on 'Instagram' with a

twist on his iconic 'Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham' dialogue and stated, "Amul ne Keh Diya, Bas Keh Diya." A line that said everything, with exactly the lightness and wit that only he could pull off.

For over five decades, an 'Amul' topical has been an unofficial barometer of what has truly captured India's imagination. Joining that canon, Karan Johar becomes the first Indian filmmaker to attend the Met Gala and to be immortalised by the 'Amul' girl for it. Two firsts. One very proud moment.



**The iconic dairy brand celebrated Johar's historic appearance at the 2026 Met Gala with a topical**

## 'Elle' drops exclusive images and official teaser trailer

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

Ahead of Amazon's May 11 upfront presentation in New York, 'Prime Video' released exclusive images and the official teaser trailer for 'Elle', the highly anticipated 'Legally Blonde' prequel. The series, produced by 'Amazon MGM Studios' in association with 'Hello Sunshine', premieres on July 1.

Ahead of the series' debut, 'Prime Video' has also ordered a second season of 'Elle'.



**The coming-of-age series from 'Amazon MGM Studios' and 'Hello Sunshine' premieres on July 1**

Season one follows Elle Woods before she was a fish-out-of-water at Harvard. We meet her in 1995 as a fish in the tumultuous waters of high school, where she encounters tricky friendships, forbidden romance and questionable fashion choices. Through it all, Elle uses her family as a touchstone and forms an even tighter bond with her mother, proving that they can get through anything life throws their way as long as they have each other. With each challenge she faces, Elle grows closer to the Elle Woods we know and love today.

Created by Laura Kittrell ('High School', 'Insecure'), 'Elle' is co-show-

run and executive produced by Kittrell and Caroline Dries. Reese Witherspoon, Lauren Neustadter, Amanda Brown and Marc Platt also serve as executive producers. Jason Moore ('Pitch Perfect') directed the first two episodes of season one and also serves as an executive producer. Bryan J Raber and Asmita Paranjape serve as producers. Josie Craven and Jen Regan serve as supervising producers.

The cast of season one includes Lexi Minnetree as Elle Woods, June Diane Raphael as Elle's mother Eva and Tom Everett Scott as her father

Wyatt, alongside Jacob Moskovitz, Gabrielle Policano, Chandler Kinney, Zac Looker, and Amy Pietz. Recurring cast members include Jessica Belkin, Danielle Chand, Matt Oberg, Chloe Wepper, Logan Shroyer, Sharon Taylor, David Burtka, Brad Harder, Kayla Maisonet, Lisa Yamada and James Van Der Beek.

## THE FIRST 'THE FAST & THE FURIOUS' MOVIE Cannes Film Festival to host a special screening



NEW DELHI: The 79th Festival de Cannes is celebrating the 25th anniversary of 'The Fast and the Furious' by hosting a special 'Midnight Screening' of the movie that became a cultural phenomenon worldwide when it was released in 2001.

The screening on May 13 at the Grand Lumiere Theatre of the Palais des Festivals, the Festival de Cannes, will be attended by stars Vin Diesel, Jordana Brewster, producer Neal H Mortiz and Meadow Walker, the daughter of the film's late star Paul Walker.

A high-octane thriller set amid the street-racing culture of Los Angeles, the 'Universal Picture' film was produced by Neal H Mortiz, directed by Rob Cohen

**The screening will be held on May 13 at the Grand Lumiere Theatre of the Palais des Festivals**

and featured Diesel as Dominic Toretto, Walker as Brian O'Conner, Brewster as Mia and Michelle Rodriguez as Letty.

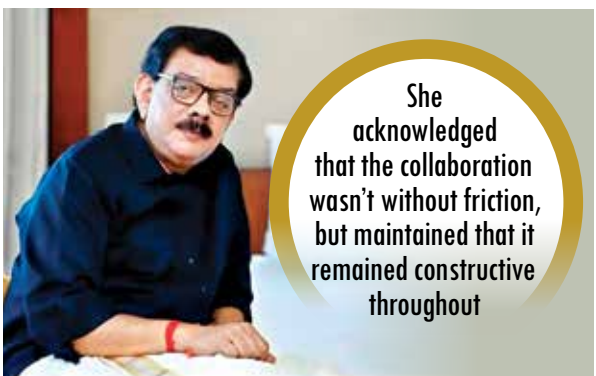
Since its release in 2001, the franchise has gone on to spawn 11 films that have earned more than 7 billion US dollars at the box office worldwide to become Universal's most profitable and longest-running franchise.

## 'THANK YOU FOR THE BIGGEST HIT OF MY CAREER'

**Ektaa Kapoor penned a note for Priyadarshan after Bhooth Bangla's Rs 231 crore box office success**

Producer Ektaa Kapoor has thanked filmmaker Priyadarshan for the box office success of the horror-comedy 'Bhooth Bangla', calling it the biggest hit of her career. The Akshay Kumar starrer crossed Rs 231 crore worldwide, becoming one of 2026's biggest Bollywood box office successes.

Taking to 'Instagram', Ektaa Kapoor shared a series of selfies with Priyadarshan alongside a heartfelt note. She wrote, "I was working with a man who was doing his 100th film. The world expected fireworks when two headstrong people like us came together, but what they didn't see was the deep-rooted mutual respect that defined our journey. I don't think I've had more fun working with anyone than @priyadarshan.official."



priyadarshan.official."

Ektaa revealed a telling detail about Priyadarshan's work philosophy. She wrote, "The first thing he asked me was, 'Ekta, are you making money on this film? I don't work on a film if my producer doesn't make money.'"

**She acknowledged that the collaboration wasn't without friction, but maintained that it remained constructive throughout**

She added that this rare belief system immediately gave her confidence, saying she knew 'the company's money and the film were both in the right hands'.

Ektaa also acknowledged that the collaboration wasn't

without friction, but maintained, it remained constructive throughout. "It's not to say we never had our disagreements, but it was always respectful," she noted, adding that she firmly believes a director must steer the ship forward.

She concluded her post with, "Thank you, Priyanshu Sir, for your vision, your discipline and for giving me the biggest hit of my career! Couldn't be more grateful." AGENCIES

